The Gutter and the Plenum

Paginal Eternalism, Horror Pleni, and the Imaginal Commons in the Work of Alan Moore

A doctoral thesis, 2026

Abstract

This thesis argues that the work of Alan Moore (b. 1953) — comics, novels, performance workings, essays, and magical-theoretical writings produced between the early 1980s and the inauguration of the *Long London* sequence in 2024 — articulates a single, internally coherent cosmology, here designated the *Plenary Codex*. Criticism has habitually partitioned Moore into successive personae: the revisionist of the superhero, the neo-Victorian Gothicist, the Hermetic magician, the psychogeographer of Northampton. Against this partition I contend that four axioms recur beneath every phase of the work and govern its form as rigorously as its content: that time is a completed solid, co-present in all its moments (eternalism); that ideas constitute an ontologically real and collectively inhabited territory (Moore's "Ideaspace," cognate with Henry Corbin's *mundus imaginalis* and Karl Popper's World 3); that every locus is the centre of the whole (the Eliadean *axis mundi*, the Borgesian Aleph, the self-similar fractal); and that consciousness is the act of reading — the movement of attention across a fixed and finished page.

The principal claim is that these axioms are not borrowed metaphysics illustrated in comics but the formal grammar of the comics page raised to the rank of cosmology. The page, on which every panel is simultaneously present and on which narrative time exists only as the reader's passage across the interpanel gutter, is the working model of Moore's universe. From this identification follow, with near-deductive necessity, the remaining commitments of the oeuvre. Moore's definition of magic as the manipulation of symbols to alter consciousness ceases to resemble a mystical evasion and appears instead as the only coherent account of efficacious action available in a block universe, where events cannot be altered but their reading can — a relation this study names the *paginal entailment*. His eschatology, culminating in *Jerusalem* (2016), construes death as the passage from character to reader of one's own completed life and substitutes for the Last Judgment a forensic inquest. His politics — anarchist, anti-fascist,

anti-corporate — is a defence of an *imaginal commons* against enclosure, which emerges as the cardinal crime of the corpus whether perpetrated by the state (*V for Vendetta*), by patriarchal myth (*From Hell*), by utilitarian technocracy (*Watchmen*), by a colonising mythos (*Providence*), or by the intellectual-property regime that has enclosed Moore's own creations. And his signature affect, here named *horror pleni*, inverts the Lovecraftian *horror vacui*: it is the dread of a universe in which nothing is ever lost, every atrocity is permanently occurring, and every grace is equally indestructible.

The study proceeds in three movements. Part One reconstructs the genealogies of these commitments in Hermetic, Kabbalistic, and Thelemic tradition (Bruno, Dee, the Golden Dawn, Crowley, Spare, Fortune); in the philosophy and physics of time (Augustine, Boethius, McTaggart, Minkowski, the Hintons, Ouspensky, Nietzsche, Bergson); in English radical and visionary dissent (Winstanley, Bunyan, Blake, Clare, Shelley); and in the anarchist canon (Proudhon, Bakunin, Kropotkin). Part Two reads the major works — *Marvelman/Miracleman*, *V for Vendetta*, *Swamp Thing*, *Watchmen*, *From Hell*, *Promethea*, *The League of Extraordinary Gentlemen*, *Voice of the Fire*, *Jerusalem*, *Providence*, and *The Great When* — as successive demonstrations of the Codex. Part Three situates Moore comparatively among weird, Gothic, folk-horror, and mythopoeic traditions (Lovecraft, Machen, Chambers, M. R. James, Kneale, Garner, Holdstock, Barker, Ligotti, Gaiman, Pratchett, Morrison, Borges, Dick, Tolkien, Lewis, Clarke, Miéville, Jemisin), proposing a tripartite taxonomy of cosmic dread — *horror vacui*, *horror vitae*, *horror pleni* — before formalising *paginal eternalism* as a general theory. The theory culminates in a *gutter theology* in which the sacred is located neither above nor within but between: in the uninscribed interstice where the reader's closure occurs, where the dispossessed live, and where the only freedom available in a finished universe is exercised. The thesis concludes by identifying a *representational antinomy* at the ethical centre of Moore's practice — his simultaneous insistence on the reality and on the harmlessness of fiction — and proposes its resolution: in a plenary cosmos, to depict is to build, and every author is answerable in perpetuity for the rooms they add to the common house of the imagination.

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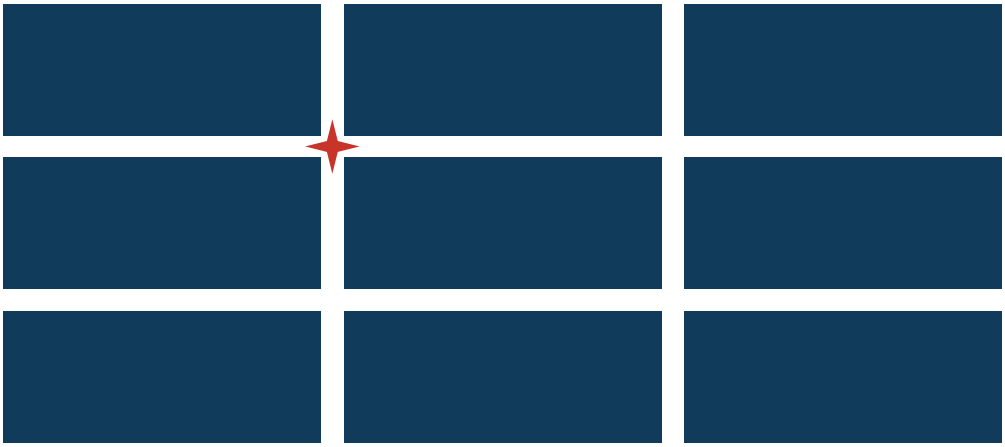
Note on Texts, Citation, and Abbreviations

Because Moore's comics have circulated as serial issues, collected editions, recoloured reissues, and oversized "absolute" formats with divergent paginations, comics are cited here by chapter or issue rather than by page (thus *W* IV for *Watchmen*, chapter IV; *ST* #21 for *Saga of the Swamp Thing* #21). *From Hell* is cited by chapter and, for its apparatus, by appendix; *Jerusalem* by its three books, "The Boroughs," "Mansoul," and "Vernall's Inquest." Moore's interviews, documentary appearances, and performance texts are cited by occasion and year.

Primary texts still in copyright are paraphrased rather than quoted. This is partly interpretive discipline, since paraphrase forces the critic to commit to a reading, and partly a matter of consistency, since the ownership of imaginative property is one of this study's objects. Direct quotation is reserved for public-domain sources, which are given in the original language where the original sharpens the argument. Artistic collaborators are named at the first substantive discussion of each work; the collaborative ontology of comics is itself treated in Chapter 3.

Abbreviatic	Work	Principal collaborator(s)	Dates
MM	*Marvelman* / *Miracleman*	Garry Leach, Alan Davis, Rick Veitch, John Totleben	1982–89
VfV	*V for Vendetta*	David Lloyd	1982–89
ST	*Saga of the Swamp Thing* / *Swamp Thing*	Stephen Bissette, John Totleben, Rick Veitch	1984–87
W	*Watchmen*	Dave Gibbons, John Higgins	1986–87

Abbreviatic	Work	Principal collaborator(s)	Dates
FH	*From Hell*	Eddie Campbell	1989–96; coll. 1999
LG	*Lost Girls*	Melinda Gebbie	1991–2006
VotF	*Voice of the Fire*	— (prose)	1996
P	*Promethea*	J. H. Williams III, Mick Gray	1999–2005
LOEG	*The League of Extraordinary Gentlemen*	Kevin O'Neill	1999–2019
Neo	*Neonomicon*	Jacen Burrows	2010
Prov	*Providence*	Jacen Burrows	2015–17
J	*Jerusalem*	— (prose)	2016
GW	*The Great When*	— (prose)	2024



Introduction

The Plenary Hypothesis

> *I must Create a System, or be enslav'd by another Mans*
> *I will not Reason & Compare: my business is to Create*
>
> — William Blake, *Jerusalem: The Emanation of the Giant Albion* (1804–20), plate 10

> *We are all in the gutter, but some of us are looking at the stars.*
>
> — Oscar Wilde, *Lady Windermere's Fan* (1892), Act III

0.1 The Problem of the Partitioned Author

The critical reception of Alan Moore has been organised less by an argument than by a chronology. Each phase of a career unusually marked by ruptures has generated its own scholarly idiom. The Moore of *Marvelman*, *Swamp Thing*, and *Watchmen* has been read as the decisive revisionist of the superhero genre, whether through Harold Bloom's agonistics of influence (Klock 2002), through the sociology of modern myth (Reynolds 1992), or through the poetics and political economy of a single canonical text (Hoberek 2014). The Moore of *From Hell* and *The League of Extraordinary Gentlemen* belongs to studies of neo-Victorianism, the urban Gothic, and intertextual pastiche. The Moore who announced on his fortieth birthday, in November 1993, that he had become a magician has been treated variously as a biographical curiosity, a countercultural provocation, or — in the more sympathetic studies of Di Liddo (2009), Parkin (2013), and Gray (2017) — as the culmination of a performative and dissident practice rooted in the underground. The Moore of *Voice of the Fire* and *Jerusalem* has entered the discourse of psychogeography and regional literature, alongside Iain Sinclair and Peter Ackroyd.

The partition is not merely a convenience of disciplinary specialisation. It encodes a substantive assumption: that Moore's interests changed, that the political satirist became an occultist, that the formalist of the nine-panel grid became a visionary novelist, and that the movement between these positions is best narrated as a sequence of conversions. This thesis contests that assumption. It argues that the apparent conversions are better understood as successive disclosures of a single ontology, present in embryo in the earliest work and progressively made explicit, and that this ontology is not a thematic preoccupation laid over the work but the structural principle generating it.

0.2 The Thesis

The argument may be stated in a sequence of propositions, each defended in the chapters that follow.

First, Moore's corpus presupposes four axioms. The *chronotopic axiom* holds that time is a completed four-dimensional solid in which past, present, and future are equally real and permanently co-present. The *imaginal axiom* holds that ideas — gods, archetypes, fictional characters, mathematical objects — inhabit a real and collectively accessible territory, which Moore calls Ideaspace. The *central axiom* holds that every locus is the centre of the whole: that the Boroughs of Northampton are as legitimately the navel of the world as Jerusalem, and that any fragment of history, rightly examined, contains the pattern of the entire culture. The *noetic axiom* holds that consciousness is an act of reading: the traversal, by attention, of a structure that is already complete.

Second, these four axioms are the formal properties of the comics page elevated into a metaphysics. On the page, all panels are simultaneously present (the chronotopic axiom); characters persist as patterns transmissible among artists, writers, and readers independent of any single body (the imaginal axiom); any panel may enter into relation with any other across the whole of a work, a property Thierry Groensteen names *braiding* (the central axiom); and narrative time exists only as the reader's passage across the unmarked gutter between panels, where the act Scott McCloud calls *closure* takes place (the noetic axiom). I call the resulting doctrine *paginal eternalism*, and the cosmology it organises the *Plenary Codex*.

Third, from paginal eternalism follow the remaining commitments of the oeuvre. Because a block universe forbids the alteration of events, efficacious action can consist only in the alteration of the consciousness that reads them; Moore's famous definition of magic as the manipulation of symbols to change consciousness is therefore not an evasion of magic's claims but their only coherent form. I call this the *paginal entailment*. Because the completed universe is read rather than lived through, death becomes the transition from the condition of a character to that of a reader of one's own life — the eschatology of *Jerusalem*. Because Ideaspace is a territory, it can be held in common or enclosed; Moore's politics, from *V for Vendetta* to his disputes with DC Comics and Marvel, is a defence of an *imaginal commons* against enclosure. And because nothing in the block is ever lost, the specific dread of Moore's fiction is not the Lovecraftian terror of a void but its inverse, which I call *horror pleni*: the horror of plenitude, of a universe in

which every atrocity is permanently occurring — and its obverse, *gloria pleni*, in which every grace is equally indestructible.

Fourth, this cosmology locates the sacred in a specific place: the gutter. The term condenses four registers that Moore's work persistently superimposes — the formal interstice between panels; the social gutter of the slum, of Whitechapel and the Boroughs; the theological interval of the Lurianic *tzimtzum*, in which the Creator withdraws to make room for the created; and the "gutter press," whose invention of "Jack the Ripper" *From Hell* stages as the birth of the twentieth century. The resulting *gutter theology* holds that the sacred is neither transcendent nor possessed but interstitial: it occurs in the uninscribed space where connection is made.

Fifth and finally, the cosmology exposes an internal contradiction in Moore's ethics of representation. He holds that fictions are real and world-shaping, and he has also defended his most contested works by insisting that fiction is a protected space whose contents harm no one. This *representational antinomy* cannot survive his own metaphysics. Its resolution — that in a plenary cosmos to depict is to build, and that authors answer in perpetuity for what they build — is the normative conclusion of the thesis.

0.3 Method: Hermetic Materialism

The study combines four methods, each disciplining the others. Comics formalism (Eisner 1985; McCloud 1993; Groensteen 1999) supplies the description of the page as a spatio-temporal object. Intellectual history supplies the genealogy of Moore's sources, distinguishing what he inherited, what he transformed, and what he invented. Comparative mythology and comparative literature supply the horizon against which the specificity of Moore's cosmology becomes legible. Political economy — the history of enclosure from the Tudor and Stuart commons to the copyright regime of the culture industries — supplies the material ground of the imaginal commons.

The synthesising stance I call *Hermetic materialism*, a term intended to describe Moore's practice as much as my own. It refuses two reductions. It refuses the idealist reduction, which would treat Moore's magic as a theory of a supernatural order behind appearances, and the materialist reduction, which would treat it as mere metaphor or self-mythologisation. It treats the symbolic order as possessing material effects and material conditions as possessing symbolic depth, and it reads the Hermetic axiom of correspondence — as above, so below — as a principle of structural homology between the page, the person, the city, and the cosmos. Throughout, the method is immanent: Moore's work is tested against its own axioms, and its failures are identified where it betrays them.

0.4 Architecture of the Argument

Part One reconstructs the genealogies. Chapter 1 traces Moore's identification of art and magic through the Hermetic, Kabbalistic, and Thelemic traditions, through the philology of *grammar*, *glamour*, and *grimoire*, and through the puppet-god Glycon, and situates Ideaspace among its ancestors from Plato to Corbin, Popper, and Barfield. Chapter 2 reconstructs the eternalist lineage from Augustine and Boethius through McTaggart, Minkowski, the Hintons, and Ouspensky, and demonstrates that the comics page is its exact formal model. Chapter 3 situates Moore's anarchism within English radical dissent and the history of enclosure, and extends the analysis to the enclosure of Moore's own creations.

Part Two reads the corpus. Chapter 4 treats *Marvelman/Miracleman*, *Captain Britain*, and *Watchmen* as a political theology of the superhero. Chapter 5 develops an ontology of the persona from *Swamp Thing*, *V for Vendetta*, and the figure of the mask. Chapter 6 reads *From Hell* as a treatise on the architecture of atrocity and the fractal epistemology of history. Chapter 7 reads *Promethea* and *The League of Extraordinary Gentlemen* as complementary theories of the literary commons. Chapter 8 reads *Voice of the Fire*, *Jerusalem*, and *The Great When* as the fullest statement of plenary eschatology. Chapter 9 reads the Lovecraftian cycle — *The Courtyard*, *Neonomicon*, *Providence* — as the dark twin of *Promethea* and as the site where the representational antinomy becomes acute.

Part Three compares and synthesises. Chapter 10 proposes the taxonomy of *horror vacui*, *horror vitae*, and *horror pleni* and situates Moore among the weird, the haunted, and the mythopoeic. Chapter 11 formalises paginal eternalism as a general theory, derives the paginal entailment, articulates gutter theology, resolves the representational antinomy, and proposes a method of *plenary criticism*. The Conclusion returns to Moore's valediction to comics — Prospero's drowned book — and argues that in a plenary cosmos no book can be drowned.

I

1
The Bardic Inheritance

2
Time Is a Solid

3
The Commons and the Enclosure

Part One

Genealogies



The Bardic Inheritance

Magic as Art, Language as Spell, and the Genealogy of Ideaspace

Moore's magic is a theory of signification with an ontology attached. Its central claim is that signs act upon consciousness, that consciousness is the site at which reality appears, and that signs therefore act upon the appearing of reality. This chapter reconstructs that claim from its sources, beginning with the most deliberately scandalous of them.

1.1 The Declaration of 1993 and the Puppet God

On 18 November 1993, his fortieth birthday, Moore announced that he had become a magician. The announcement had the quality of a provocation, and Moore has never denied its theatrical dimension; but its theological content was precise. The deity he took as tutelary was Glycon, the serpent-god whose oracle flourished in Paphlagonia in the second century CE and whose cult is known chiefly through Lucian of Samosata's hostile pamphlet *Alexander, or the False Prophet*. According to Lucian, the prophet Alexander of Abonoteichus manufactured the god from a tame snake fitted with an artificial, humanlike head whose mouth could be worked by concealed hairs. Glycon, in short, was a puppet.

Moore's choice of an attested fraud is the founding gesture of his theology, not an embarrassment within it. To adopt a god whose fraudulence is documented by a contemporary satirist is to declare in advance that the question of the god's material provenance is irrelevant to the question of its reality. A god, in Moore's repeatedly stated view, exists unarguably as an idea; and as an idea it possesses whatever powers ideas possess — to organise attention, to compel behaviour, to sustain institutions, to alter consciousness. The puppet is not the god's disproof but its definition. The hand inside the puppet is the worshipper's own; the voice that issues from it is the community's; and the efficacy of the oracle is the efficacy of a shared fiction. Glycon thus becomes the emblem of what this thesis will call the *imaginal axiom*: that ideas are real without being material, and that their reality is not diminished by the discovery that we made them.

Heinrich von Kleist's essay *Über das Marionettentheater* (1810) supplies an unexpected philosophical key to the choice. Kleist's interlocutor argues that grace, lost to the self-conscious human dancer, reappears in its purest form only at the two extremes of consciousness: "in dem Gliedermann, oder in dem Gott" — in the jointed doll, or in the god. Glycon is the precise coincidence of Kleist's two extremes: a marionette that is a god. The figure will recur in Chapter 10 as the hinge between Moore's affirmative cosmology and Thomas Ligotti's pessimism, for which the discovery that one is a puppet is the supreme horror.

1.2 Grammar, Glamour, Grimoire: The Philology of Enchantment

Moore's account of magic rests on an argument from etymology that he has rehearsed in interviews, in *Promethea*, and in the documentary *The Mindscape of Alan Moore* (2003). The argument observes that the language of enchantment and the language of literacy share their roots. *Grimoire*, the book of spells, is an alteration of the French *grammaire*. The Middle English *gramarye*, learning in general, came to denote occult learning in particular. *Glamour* is a Scots alteration of *grammar*, which Walter Scott popularised in the sense of a magical spell. And the two senses of *spell* — to enchant and to name the letters of a word — descend from a common Germanic root meaning to tell or recount. For Moore these are not curiosities but evidence: the culture remembers in its vocabulary that writing was once understood as a magical operation.

To this philology Moore joins a historical claim that magic was anciently called simply "the Art," and a figure, the bard, in whom art and magic were undivided. The Irish legal and literary tradition preserves the *glám dícenn*, a satire with the force of a curse, and the story, recorded in Cormac's Glossary, of the poet Néde, whose satire raised blisters on the face of King Caier and drove him from his throne. Moore cites the bardic satirist as the model of a writer whose words produce physical and political effects. The claim converges with Percy Bysshe Shelley's thesis in *A Defence of Poetry* (written 1821, published 1840) that "Poets are the unacknowledged legislators of the World." Moore radicalises Shelley by removing the qualifier: the poet legislates not metaphorically but operatively, because the symbolic order the poet modifies is the medium in which the social world is constituted.

The definition of magic that results has become the most cited sentence in Moore's non-fiction: magic, he says, is the manipulation of symbols, words, or images to achieve changes in consciousness, and art, so defined, is identical with it. The lineage of the definition is explicit. Aleister Crowley, in *Magick in Theory and Practice* (1929), had defined magick as the science and art of causing change in conformity with will. Dion Fortune psychologised Crowley's formula by specifying that the changes in question are changes in consciousness. Moore's contribution is to complete Fortune's interiorisation by identifying the will-directed manipulation of consciousness with the ordinary operations of the artist. The emphasis falls, decisively, on consciousness rather than on external events. Chapter 11 will argue that this emphasis is not a retreat from magical efficacy but a logical

consequence of Moore's eternalism.

1.3 The Hermetic Lineage: From Thoth to the Golden Dawn

Moore's magic is Hermetic in descent. Its presiding figure is Thoth, the Egyptian god of writing, reckoning, and magic, whom the Greeks assimilated to Hermes and whom late antiquity elevated into Hermes Trismegistus, putative author of the *Corpus Hermeticum* and of the *Emerald Tablet*, whose axiom of correspondence — that which is above is as that which is below — underwrites every homology Moore draws between the page, the body, the city, and the cosmos. The identification of the god of magic with the god of writing is the mythological ground of the art–magic identity: in the Hermetic world-picture, writing is a cosmological technique.

The Renaissance recovery of Hermeticism, beginning with Marsilio Ficino's translation of the *Corpus* in 1463, produced the figure of the magus as scholar and artist. Frances Yates's studies (1964, 1966) reconstructed the most important of its techniques for Moore's purposes: the art of memory, in which ideas are lodged as images in imagined architectures, so that thought becomes a navigation through places. Giulio Camillo's Theatre of Memory and Giordano Bruno's *De umbris idearum* (1582) treated the mind as a space furnished with images through which the trained practitioner could move and by which he could be transformed. Ideaspace, as later sections show, is the art of memory turned from a private technique into a public territory. John Dee, mathematician, astrologer, and, with Edward Kelley, recipient of the "Enochian" angelic communications of the 1580s, stands at the head of the specifically English lineage Moore claims — the magus as servant of the state and as its secret critic, the scholar whose library was itself a cosmos.

The Hermetic Order of the Golden Dawn, founded in 1888 by William Wynn Westcott, Samuel Liddell MacGregor Mathers, and William Robert Woodman, systematised this inheritance into a curriculum. Its synthesis attached the twenty-two trumps of the Tarot to the paths of the Kabbalistic Tree of Life, organised initiation as an ascent through the sephiroth, and absorbed elements of Egyptian, Rosicrucian, and Enochian practice. Among its members were W. B. Yeats, Arthur Machen, Algernon Blackwood, and Crowley; the overlap between the order and the history of weird fiction is not incidental, and it will inform the comparative argument of Chapter 10. Crowley's subsequent system, Thelema, inaugurated by the *Book of the Law* (received in Cairo in 1904), contributed the most influen-

tial modern definition of magic and, in *The Book of Thoth* (1944) and the Tarot painted to his specifications by Lady Frieda Harris, the iconographic programme that *Promethea* #12 reworks.

Austin Osman Spare, expelled from Crowley's circle and later canonised by chaos magic, supplied the technique most directly relevant to Moore's art. In *The Book of Pleasure* (1913) Spare described the sigil: a statement of desire reduced, by the elimination of repeated letters, to a glyph, charged in a state of mental vacancy, and then deliberately forgotten so that it can operate below conscious resistance. Grant Morrison's essay "Pop Magic!" (2003) extended the technique into the *hypersigil*, an extended artwork engineered to alter its creator's life. Moore's relation to this lineage is ambivalent. His essay "Fossil Angels" (written c. 2002) diagnoses contemporary occultism as fossilised — its grades, regalia, and inherited rituals the calcified remains of what was once a living art — and prescribes magic's return to its origin in artistic practice. The grimoire is to be succeeded by the novel, the comic, and the performance.

1.4 Ideaspace and Its Ancestors

The central concept of Moore's metaphysics is Ideaspace: a space of mind that is collective rather than private, navigable rather than merely contained, and populated by every entity human consciousness has produced or encountered — gods, demons, archetypes, mathematical objects, theories, and fictional characters. Each individual mind, in Moore's recurrent figure, opens onto this space as a house opens onto a shared street. The concept is given its fullest narrative realisation in *Promethea*'s Immateria and its fullest eschatological realisation in *Jerusalem*'s Mansoul, but it is implicit as early as *Swamp Thing*'s Green and *Captain Britain*'s Omniverse.

Ideaspace has an extensive ancestry, and its specificity emerges only against it. Plato's realm of Forms is its oldest relative, but the differences are decisive: the Forms are eternal perfections of which the sensible world is a degraded copy, whereas Ideaspace contains the base, the grotesque, and the ephemeral alongside the sublime, and it is generated by human minds rather than prior to them. Plotinus's *Nous* and Bruno's shadows of ideas share Ideaspace's character as a place of thought, but not its democracy. C. G. Jung's collective unconscious, with its archetypes and, in Jung's late theory, its "psychoid" stratum straddling mind and matter, supplies the strongest psychological precedent; but Jung's archetypes are few, inherited, and quasi-biological, whereas Ideaspace is endlessly populated and historically accreting. Pierre Teilhard de Chardin's noosphere (1955) supplies an evolutionary image of a thinking envelope around the planet, and Karl Popper's World 3 (1972) supplies its most sober analogue: a realm of the objective contents of thought — problems, theories, arguments, stories — which, though produced by minds, achieves autonomy, possesses unintended properties discoverable only after creation, and acts back upon the physical world through human agents.

The ancestor most illuminating for this thesis is Henry Corbin's *mundus imaginalis*. Drawing on Suhrawardi and Ibn 'Arabi, Corbin (1964) insisted on distinguishing the *imaginal* — a real, intermediate world of subtle bodies and autonomous images, the *'ālam al-mithāl*, accessible to the creative imagination as an organ of perception — from the *imaginary*, the merely unreal. Suhrawardi had named this realm *Nā-kojā-Ābād*, the land of no-where. Moore's Ideaspace is the *mundus imaginalis* secularised and democratised: secularised, because it requires no theophany, only attention; democratised, because it is the common address not merely of the mystic but of every reader, including the reader of pulp magazines

and superhero comics. Corbin's imaginal realm is a place of visionary privilege; Moore's is a public thoroughfare. This democratisation is the theological premise of Moore's treatment of fictional characters as beings with interests, and therefore of the politics developed in Chapter 3.

Owen Barfield's *Saving the Appearances* (1957) supplies the historical frame within which Moore's magical project becomes intelligible as a programme. Barfield argued that human consciousness had passed from an *original participation*, in which mind and phenomena were not yet sundered, through the modern "idolatry" of the detached observer who mistakes the appearances for independent objects, toward a possible *final participation*, in which the participatory relation would be recovered self-consciously. Moore's corpus stages each phase. *Voice of the Fire* opens inside an original participation in which the Neolithic narrator cannot distinguish dream, landscape, and self; *Watchmen*'s Dr Manhattan embodies the terminal detachment of the observer; *Promethea*'s apocalypse imagines final participation as a collective event.

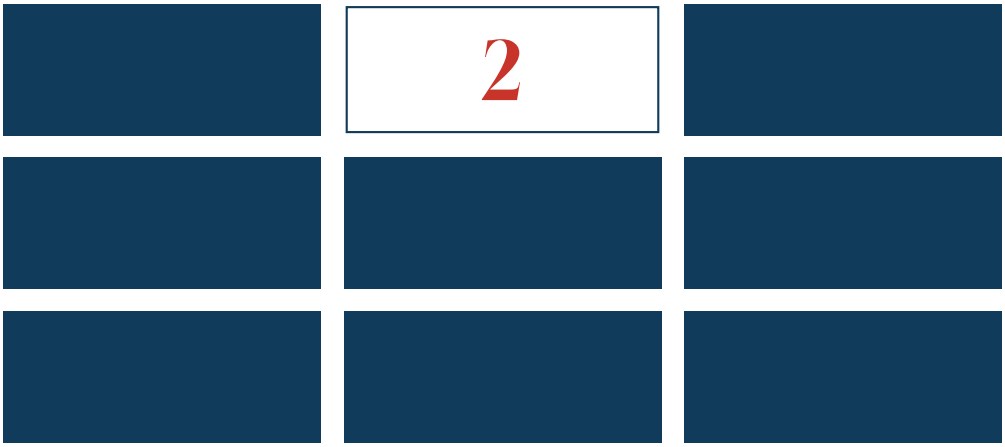
1.5 The Workings: Performance as Ritual

Between 1994 and 2001 Moore, with the musicians Tim Perkins and David J and others, produced a series of performance pieces that he understood as magical workings in the technical sense: *The Moon and Serpent Grand Egyptian Theatre of Marvels* (1994), *The Birth Caul* (1995), *The Highbury Working* (1997), *Snakes and Ladders* (1999), and *Angel Passage* (2001). *The Birth Caul*, composed after the death of Moore's mother and organised around the caul discovered among her effects, performs a regression through the stages of a life toward the membrane that separates the unborn from the world — what Moore described as a shamanism of childhood. *Snakes and Ladders*, performed at Red Lion Square, makes Arthur Machen a tutelary presence and maps spiritual ascent and fall onto the board game of the title. *The Highbury Working* is a psychogeographic séance on a single London district. *Angel Passage* is an extended invocation of William Blake. Eddie Campbell's adaptations of two of these pieces in *A Disease of Language* (2005) translated the workings back into comics, confirming the convertibility of ritual and page.

The workings matter for two reasons. They demonstrate that the art–magic identity is for Moore a practice and not merely a thesis. And they show the practice to be psychogeographic from the start: each working is attached to a place, and each treats the place as a palimpsest of times and voices accessible through a disciplined act of attention. Moore's long friendship with Steve Moore (1949–2014), the magician, Fortean, and comics writer who was no relation, extends the pattern. In *Unearthing* (2006) Moore wrote his friend's life as the geology and mythology of Shooters Hill in south-east London, so that biography becomes a stratigraphy of place; Steve Moore's own *Somnium* (2011) rewrote the myth of Endymion and Selene in the light of his lifelong devotion to the moon goddess. Their jointly authored *Moon and Serpent Bumper Book of Magic* (2024) completes the trajectory by casting a grimoire in the form of a children's annual: the hieratic text deliberately rendered vernacular, magic returned to the commons.

1.6 Interim Conclusion

The magic reconstructed here is neither supernaturalist nor merely metaphorical. It is a *semiotic realism*: a doctrine that signs operate on consciousness, that consciousness is where reality appears, and that ideas, once produced, inhabit a common territory and act through those who attend to them. The doctrine leaves one question unanswered: what kind of reality is it upon whose appearing the magician acts? Chapter 2 answers that it is a reality already complete — and that this completion determines everything else.



2

Time Is a Solid

The Eternalist Lineage and the Comics Page as Chronotope

Moore is an eternalist, and his eternalism is the load-bearing wall of his cosmology. He has stated in numerous interviews, and *Jerusalem* dramatises at a length of more than a thousand pages, the conviction that the universe is a completed four-dimensional solid in which every moment exists permanently; that the experience of passage is a property of consciousness rather than of time; and that at death consciousness does not cease but comes to inhabit the totality of the life it has lived. This chapter reconstructs the genealogy of that conviction and then demonstrates its formal identity with the comics page.

2.1 Eternity Before Physics: Augustine and Boethius

The Western problem of time begins with Augustine's confession of perplexity in Book XI of the *Confessions*: "Quid est ergo tempus? Si nemo ex me quaerat, scio; si quaerenti explicare velim, nescio" — what, then, is time? If no one asks me, I know; if I wish to explain it to one who asks, I do not know. Augustine's solution locates time in the soul as a *distentio animi*, a stretching of the mind between memory, attention, and expectation. The solution matters for Moore because it makes the experience of temporal passage a property of the attending mind — precisely the noetic axiom, which locates the "now" in the reader rather than in the world.

Boethius supplied the complementary doctrine. In the fifth book of the *Consolation of Philosophy* (c. 524), Lady Philosophy reconciles divine foreknowledge with human freedom by defining eternity not as endless duration but as simultaneity: "aeternitas igitur est interminabilis vitae tota simul et perfecta possessio" — the complete, simultaneous, and perfect possession of unending life. God does not foresee our acts; God sees them, all at once, as a spectator on a height sees the whole of a road. Moore's eschatology can be stated as a democratisation of the Boethian vantage. In *Jerusalem*'s Mansoul, every human being after death acquires the *tota simul* view of their own life that Boethius reserved for God. The theological privilege becomes the common inheritance of the dead.

2.2 Eternity After Physics: The Block Universe

The year 1908 produced, independently, the two founding documents of modern eternalism. In "The Unreality of Time," J. M. E. McTaggart distinguished the *A-series*, in which events are ordered as past, present, and future, from the *B-series*, in which they are ordered only as earlier and later than one another. McTaggart argued that the A-series is incoherent and that time is therefore unreal; later philosophers who rejected his idealism retained his distinction, and the "B-theory" — on which temporal becoming is perspectival and all times are equally real — became the philosophical form of eternalism. In the same year, in a lecture at Cologne, Hermann Minkowski gave Einstein's special relativity its geometrical expression and announced the dissolution of space and time as independent entities: "Von Stund an sollen Raum für sich und Zeit für sich völlig zu Schatten herabsinken, und nur noch eine Art Union der beiden soll Selbständigkeit bewahren" — henceforth space by itself and time by itself are to sink into mere shadows, and only a kind of union of the two shall preserve independence.

From the relativity of simultaneity, Hilary Putnam (1967) later argued that if events simultaneous for one observer are real, then events in another observer's past and future must be equally real, so that relativity entails a block universe. Einstein himself, consoling the family of his friend Michele Besso in 1955, wrote that for those who believe in physics the distinction between past, present, and future is only an illusion, however stubborn. Huw Price (1996) named the standpoint from which the block can be contemplated "the view from nowhen." Moore paraphrases the Besso letter often, and *Jerusalem* gives Price's abstraction a location: the view from nowhen is the view from the upper storey of a Northampton slum.

The Victorian and Edwardian popular imagination had prepared the ground. Charles Howard Hinton's essay "What Is the Fourth Dimension?" (1880) and *A New Era of Thought* (1888), which coined the word *tesseract*, proposed that three-dimensional beings are cross-sections of four-dimensional forms and that time might be the fourth dimension through which those cross-sections move. Hinton's father, James Hinton, was an aural surgeon and moral philosopher at Guy's Hospital, where William Withey Gull was physician. *From Hell* exploits the conjunction with characteristic exactness: the Hintons, father and son, become a source of Gull's conviction that his acts are inscribed in a dimension through which they reverberate. J. W. Dunne's *An Experiment with Time* (1927) popularised a serial theory of time to account for precognitive dreams. P. D. Ouspen-

sky's *Tertium Organum* (1912) and *A New Model of the Universe* (1931) combined the fourth dimension with a doctrine of eternal recurrence in which awakening remains possible.

Recurrence must be distinguished from Moore's position. Friedrich Nietzsche's demon, in §341 of *Die fröhliche Wissenschaft* (1882), proposes that one's life will return innumerable times, identical in every detail, and Nietzsche names the thought "das größte Schwergewicht," the heaviest weight. Moore's eternalism is heavier still. Recurrence implies repetition, and therefore a sequence of returns; the block implies no return at all, because nothing departs. The life is not lived again; it is never not being lived. Kurt Vonnegut's Tralfamadorians in *Slaughterhouse-Five* (1969), who perceive all moments at once as one might survey a mountain range, translated this view into a serene fatalism; *Watchmen*'s Dr Manhattan, as shown below, is the critique of that serenity. The axiom that reconciles Moore's eternalism with his materialism is Blake's, from the Proverbs of Hell in *The Marriage of Heaven and Hell*: "Eternity is in love with the productions of time." Eternity is not the negation of time but its totality, and it cherishes rather than transcends what time produces.

The philosophical opposition is Henri Bergson. In the *Essai sur les données immédiates de la conscience* (1889), Bergson argued that the spatialisation of time — its representation as a line of juxtaposed instants — falsifies lived duration, the *durée* in which moments interpenetrate. The comics page is the very spatialisation Bergson indicted: time laid out as juxtaposed images on a surface. Moore takes the side Bergson attacked. He treats the spatialised image not as a falsification of time but as its truth, and relocates *durée* — the felt passage — to the reader's movement across the page. Minkowski, not Bergson, is Moore's physicist; but Augustine, who located passage in the soul, is the bridge between them.

2.3 The Comics Page as Chronotope

Mikhail Bakhtin's *chronotope* names the intrinsic connectedness of temporal and spatial relationships in narrative. In comics the chronotope is literal. Scott McCloud (1993) observed that in comics time and space are the same: the position of a panel on the page is its position in the narrative's time, and to move the eye is to move through time. Every panel of a page, and in principle every page of a book, is simultaneously present to inspection; the reader's "present" is wherever attention rests; and the past and future of the narrative remain visible at the edges of that attention. The comics page is a block universe of finite extent.

Thierry Groensteen's *Système de la bande dessinée* (1999) refined the point. Groensteen describes the page as a *spatio-topia* and its relations as an *arthrology*, which is *restricted* where it concerns the linear sequence of adjacent panels and *general* where it concerns relations among non-adjacent panels across a page or a book. The most important of these general relations he calls *braiding* (*tressage*): the network of echoes, rhymes, and recurrences that links panels across a work irrespective of their sequential position. Braiding is the formal correlate of eternal co-presence. In a braided work, as in the block, any moment may enter into relation with any other, and meaning is produced by the totality of such relations rather than by sequence alone.

Moore's own theory of the medium, set out in *Writing for Comics* (first published in 1985), arrives at the same point from the practitioner's side. Moore argued that comics should cease to imitate cinema and should cultivate what only comics can do — above all, the reader's control of time and the possibility of juxtaposing moments that cinema must present successively. The writer's craft, so conceived, is the management of co-presence.

2.4 *Watchmen* IV: The God Who Reads

The fourth chapter of *Watchmen*, "Watchmaker," is Moore's first full demonstration of paginal eternalism, and its epigraph — Einstein's remark that had he foreseen the consequences of atomic physics he would have become a watchmaker — names its themes. Jon Osterman, the watchmaker's son transformed into Dr Manhattan by an intrinsic-field accident, narrates the chapter from Mars in a present tense that slides among 1945, 1959, 1985, and other dates without transition. Manhattan does not remember the past or foresee the future; he perceives them, as the reader perceives the whole of the chapter's pages. His mode of consciousness is the reader's mode of consciousness given to a character. Manhattan is the B-series incarnate: a being for whom the A-series, the experience of now, has become a perspective among others.

The chapter also exposes the ethical crisis of such a consciousness. A being who perceives the whole as fixed has, it seems, no reason to act and no grounds for care; Manhattan's affectlessness toward humanity is the deficit of the reader who has forgotten that the characters are lives. The resolution comes in chapter IX, "The Darkness of Mere Being," whose title derives from Jung's late reflection that the purpose of human existence is to kindle a light in the darkness of mere being. On Mars, Laurie Juspeczyk discovers that her father is the Comedian, conceived in a relationship that began with his assault on her mother and continued, years later, in consent. Manhattan, contemplating the improbability of this particular person's existence, revalues it as a "thermodynamic miracle": an event so improbable as to be, in effect, impossible, and therefore precious. Nothing has changed in the block. What has changed is Manhattan's reading of it. The sequence is the paginal entailment in narrative form: the only transformation available to a being who sees the whole is a transformation of perception, and it proves sufficient to save the world from his indifference.

The fifth chapter, "Fearful Symmetry," with its epigraph from Blake's "The Tyger," makes the same claim at the level of layout. Its page compositions mirror one another around a symmetrical central spread, so that the chapter can be read as a palindrome. Time's arrow, which governs the reading, is suspended in the architecture of the object read.

2.5 Other Chronotopic Experiments

The demonstration recurs throughout the corpus. In the third book of *The Ballad of Halo Jones* (with Ian Gibson, 1986), war on the high-gravity planet Moab is governed by relativistic time dilation, so that combatants' lives desynchronise and the war becomes a machine for the destruction of shared time. *A Small Killing* (with Oscar Zarate, 1991) pursues its protagonist, an advertising executive, with a child who is his own earlier self, persisting and accusing. The Greyshirt story "How Things Work Out" (with Rick Veitch, *Tomorrow Stories* #2, 1999) divides its pages into four horizontal tiers representing four floors of one building at four moments across the twentieth century, read concurrently, so that causes descend through the building's storeys while the reader moves laterally through time. The page becomes an architectural cross-section of a block. The final issue of *Promethea* (#32, 2005) is printed so that its pages, removed and assembled, form two continuous images: the narrative becomes a single simultaneous object, and to see it whole the reader must dismantle the codex. *Swamp Thing* #34, "Rite of Spring" (1985), dissolves panel borders into floating, interpenetrating images, rendering ecstatic communion as the collapse of sequence into simultaneity. And *Jerusalem* translates the method into prose: characters glimpse their own futures, the dead in Mansoul survey the Boroughs as one surveys a page, and chapters braid across centuries through recurring objects, places, and phrases.

2.6 The Ethics of the Block

Eternalism raises two objections that the corpus confronts directly. The first is determinism: if every act is fixed, responsibility seems void. Moore's implicit answer is compatibilist. Choices are real as structures within the block; they are not made less one's own by being permanent. The second objection is quietism: if nothing can be altered, resistance seems pointless. The answer here is that resistance, too, is a permanent feature of the block — V's acts, Evey's choice, Valerie's letter are as eternal as the regime they oppose — and that the meaning of an act does not depend on its capacity to alter an outcome but on what it is.

These answers have a cost, and the cost is the specific affect of Moore's fiction. If nothing is lost, then nothing is past. Every atrocity the corpus depicts — the Whitechapel murders, the devastation of London in *Miracleman* #15, the camp at Larkhill, the childhood of Walter Kovacs — is not merely remembered but permanently occurring. The weight Nietzsche assigned to recurrence becomes, in the block, the weight of permanence. This is the first appearance in the argument of *horror pleni*, the dread of plenitude. Its obverse, the permanence of every grace, is the consolation the corpus offers in return. Chapters 6 and 8 will show how *From Hell* and *Jerusalem* respectively explore each face.



The Commons and the Enclosure

Anarchism, Property, and the Political Economy of the Imagination

If Ideaspace is a territory, it can be held in common or fenced. This chapter argues that Moore's politics — the anarchism of *V for Vendetta*, the class consciousness of *Jerusalem*, and the decades-long dispute with the publishers who own his most famous creations — forms a single argument about enclosure, and that this argument descends from a specifically English and specifically Northamptonshire tradition of resistance to the fencing of common land.

3.1 A Common Treasury: English Radicalism and the County of Enclosure

In April 1649 Gerrard Winstanley and the Diggers began to cultivate the common land of St George's Hill in Surrey, and in *The True Levellers Standard Advanced* Winstanley declared that the Creator had made the earth "a Common Treasury" for all. The Diggers were dispersed within the year, but the idea that land, knowledge, and grace are a common inheritance unjustly privatised became a submerged current of English dissent. Christopher Hill's *The World Turned Upside Down* (1972) reconstructed the radical sects of the Revolution — Diggers, Levellers, Ranters, Muggletonians — and their antinomian conviction that the inner light overrode the moral law. E. P. Thompson's *The Making of the English Working Class* (1963) traced the survival of this current into early industrial England, and his last book, *Witness Against the Beast* (1993), located William Blake's visionary antinomianism within it. Moore's politics belongs to this lineage, which unites the defence of the commons, the dissenting conscience, and the visionary imagination.

Northamptonshire occupies a privileged place in the history of enclosure. The Midland Revolt of 1607, led in part by the itinerant agitator known as Captain Pouch, culminated in a rising at Newton, near Geddington, against enclosures made by a branch of the Tresham family; the rioters were dispersed by armed gentry with heavy loss of life. Two years earlier another Tresham, Francis, had been drawn into the Gunpowder Plot, whose principal conspirator, Robert Catesby, held the Northamptonshire manor of Ashby St Ledgers, where tradition locates the plot's planning. The county thus produced, within two years, both a popular rising against the privatisation of land and an aristocratic conspiracy against the state; Moore's work, as Chapter 5 shows, draws on both. Two centuries later John Clare, the peasant poet of Helpston, wrote the great English elegies of enclosure, in which the fencing of open fields figures as a desecration of the poor's rights and of the living landscape itself. Clare spent the last twenty-three years of his life in the Northampton General Lunatic Asylum; he reappears in *Jerusalem* as one of the town's visionaries confined by it.

Karl Marx's chapter on so-called primitive accumulation in the first volume of *Capital* (1867) supplies the theoretical frame. Enclosure, for Marx, was the historical act by which producers were separated from their means of production and common resources converted into private property, creating at once a propertyless class and a capital. The concept generalises: any process by which

a resource held or used in common is converted into an exclusive, alienable, and rent-bearing asset is an enclosure. The argument of this chapter is that Moore applies the concept, consistently and with increasing explicitness, to the imagination.

3.2 *V for Vendetta*: Anarchy as Order, Destruction as Creation

V for Vendetta, begun with David Lloyd in the British anthology *Warrior* in 1982 and completed for DC in 1988–89, imagines a Britain of the late 1990s governed, after a limited nuclear war, by the fascist party Norsefire. Written against the early Thatcher government and the revival of the far right, it pits against the regime an anarchist terrorist in a Guy Fawkes mask, a survivor of medical experiments at the Larkhill resettlement camp, who destroys the regime's symbolic and informational apparatus while re-educating a young woman, Evey Hammond, who will inherit his role. Moore's 1983 essay "Behind the Painted Smile" describes the work's assembly from a collage of sources: Orwell and Huxley, the Gothic thriller, pulp heroes, the cinema of political paranoia, and the bonfire-night effigy.

The work's political philosophy is explicitly anarchist, and its sources are canonical. V's distinction between anarchy and chaos echoes Pierre-Joseph Proudhon, who in *Qu'est-ce que la propriété?* (1840) both declared property to be theft and claimed for anarchy the character of order. V's insistence that anarchy has two faces, creator and destroyer, and that destruction must precede the building of a free society, echoes Mikhail Bakunin's essay "Die Reaktion in Deutschland" (1842), which ends: "Die Lust der Zerstörung ist eine schaffende Lust" — the urge to destroy is a creative urge. The title of the final book, "The Land of Do-As-You-Please," names the voluntary order that V believes will follow the interregnum of disorder. Peter Kropotkin's *Mutual Aid* (1902), with its argument that cooperation rather than competition drives the survival of species and communities, stands behind the hope, never more than implicit in the text, that the people of London will organise themselves once the state's apparatus is removed.

Norsefire's power, crucially, is an enclosure of narrative. Its instruments are surveillance (the Eye, the Ear, the Finger) and a monopoly on public speech: the Voice of Fate, the state broadcast that speaks with the authority of destiny. The regime's computer, Fate, which the Leader worships with an erotic devotion, is the apotheosis of the enclosed imagination: a single system that owns the future

by owning its narration. V's counter-strategy is a re-commoning of the symbolic. His Shadow Gallery is a private museum and library of the culture the state has banned — a commons in exile. His seizure of the broadcast tower returns public speech, briefly, to an unauthorised voice. His campaign of explosions targets buildings as signs: Parliament, the Old Bailey, the propaganda tower.

The work's ethical crux is the episode in which V stages Evey's arrest, imprisons her, shaves her head, and subjects her to interrogation and the threat of execution in order to free her from fear. Its centre is the letter written on toilet paper by Valerie, an actress imprisoned at Larkhill for being a lesbian, which V himself received in the adjoining cell and which he passes to Evey as the testimony of an integrity the regime could not reach. The letter is the corpus's first great act of witness, and Valerie its first secular saint. But the frame that transmits it is coercive. V authors Evey: he composes the situation, controls its meaning, and rewrites her subjectivity without her consent. Moore refuses to resolve the ambiguity, and this thesis reads the episode as the founding scene of the *representational antinomy* discussed in Chapters 9 and 11: it poses the question of whether an author may rewrite another person for her own good — the same question that later governs Moore's relations with publishers who rewrite his creations without his consent.

The afterlife of *V for Vendetta* completes its argument. From 2008 the Guy Fawkes mask, as designed by Lloyd and popularised by the 2006 film from which Moore withdrew his name, was adopted by the Anonymous collective and then by the Occupy movement and protesters worldwide. The sign escaped into the commons. Yet the commercially manufactured masks were licensed merchandise, and it was widely reported that the studio owning the film's imagery received a fee on their sale. The mask is thus a perfect instance of what Jacques Derrida, in "La pharmacie de Platon" (1968), called the *pharmakon*: at once remedy and poison, the common symbol of resistance and the enclosed commodity of an entertainment conglomerate. Moore's work does not escape the dialectic it describes; it becomes one of its exhibits.

3.3 The Enclosure of Moore

The American comic-book industry was founded on an act of enclosure. Jerry Siegel and Joe Shuster sold the rights to Superman to their publisher in 1938 for a nominal sum, and the work-for-hire system that followed made the creators of the medium's most valuable characters into employees without equity in their creations. Jack Kirby's protracted struggle with Marvel over the return of his original art in the 1980s made the system's injustice visible to a generation of creators, Moore among them.

Moore's own enclosure proceeded in three stages. The first concerned *Watchmen*. The contract under which Moore and Dave Gibbons produced it provided, according to their account, that the rights would revert to them once the work had been out of print for a specified period; the publisher's decision to keep the collected edition permanently in print — a decision made possible by its unprecedented success — meant that reversion never occurred. Andrew Hoberek's *Considering Watchmen: Poetics, Property, Politics* (2014) reads the work's formal achievement and its proprietary fate as two aspects of the same historical moment. Moore's subsequent break with DC was hastened by disputes over merchandising and a proposed ratings system. In 2012 DC published *Before Watchmen*, a set of prequels by other creators; in 2016–19 the *Rebirth* initiative and the series *Doomsday Clock* incorporated Dr Manhattan into the company's shared universe as the cosmic agent responsible for its altered continuity. The irony is exact. Moore's figure of eternalist consciousness — the being who sees the whole of time as fixed — was conscripted to explain the corporate reboot, the most characteristic temporal form of the franchise, in which no story is ever allowed to end. The god of the block universe became the editor of the enclosure.

The second stage concerned *Marvelman*. Created by Mick Anglo in 1954 as a substitute for the American Captain Marvel, whose publication had ceased after litigation, the character passed through a labyrinth of claims — the original British publisher, *Warrior*, Eclipse Comics, the purchaser of Eclipse's assets, and Neil Gaiman, who had continued Moore's run — before Marvel acquired the rights from Anglo in 2009. When Marvel reprinted Moore's stories, it did so at Moore's request without his name, crediting their author as "The Original Writer." The phrase converts the author into an epithet, a *deus absconditus* of his own creation, nameless and yet structurally indispensable — a Gnostic figure, as Chapter 4 will suggest, for a Gnostic predicament.

The third stage concerned the America's Best Comics line, launched in 1999.

Moore had committed the line to WildStorm, the studio founded by Jim Lee, which Lee sold to DC in 1998 before the line's launch; Moore, who had sworn never to work for DC again, found himself once more within its corporate structure and honoured his commitments to the artists he had engaged. The apocalypse with which *Promethea* concludes (#31–32, 2005), and which effectively closes the ABC universe, can be read in this light as an anti-enclosure gesture: an author's assertion of the right to end a world, against the franchise's imperative of perpetual continuation. Throughout the film adaptations of his work — *From Hell* (2001), *The League of Extraordinary Gentlemen* (2003), *Constantine* (2005), *V for Vendetta* (2006), *Watchmen* (2009) — Moore declined credit and directed his share of payments to his collaborators.

Moore's critique has broadened from the industry to the culture it produces. In a 2014 interview with Pádraig Ó Méalóid he traced the costumed vigilante in part to the hooded riders of D. W. Griffith's *The Birth of a Nation* (1915), adapted from Thomas Dixon's *The Clansman* (1905). In a widely reported interview of 2022 he characterised the mass adult consumption of superhero entertainment as an infantilisation that can presage fascism. The diagnosis converges with Mark Fisher's *Capitalist Realism* (2009), which describes the inability to imagine alternatives to the present order: the endlessly rebooted franchise is the narrative form of capitalist realism, a future enclosed by the perpetual return of owned properties.

3.4 The Imaginal Commons: A Theory

The preceding sections permit the formulation of a theory. If, as Chapter 1 established, Ideaspace is a real territory, then it is susceptible to the same regimes of tenure as land. It may be held in common, used by all, and enriched by use; or it may be enclosed, converted into exclusive and rent-bearing property, and policed. Moore's villains are, with remarkable consistency, enclosers of the imaginal: Norsefire, which monopolises narrative; Gargunza in *Miracleman*, who implants manufactured dreams in his subjects; William Gull in *From Hell*, who writes a patriarchal myth upon women's bodies; Adrian Veidt in *Watchmen*, who conscripts artists to manufacture an apocalypse; the occult order of *Providence*, which colonises the human imagination; and, outside the fiction, the corporation that owns characters. Moore's protagonists are, with equal consistency, commoners: V, who returns the broadcast to the public; Valerie, whose testimony circulates without property; Promethea, whose apocalypse opens the Immateria to all; the immortals of the *League*, assembled from the public domain; the dead children of *Jerusalem*, who roam an eternity no one owns.

Moore's practice enacts the theory. *The League of Extraordinary Gentlemen* is built almost entirely from public-domain literature; *Lost Girls* takes its protagonists from the same commons; the *Bumper Book of Magic* makes the grimoire vernacular; the underground magazine *Dodgem Logic* (2009–11) addressed itself to the residents of the Boroughs; and Moore's long insistence on the co-creative status of his artists — Gibbons, Lloyd, Campbell, O'Neill, Williams, Gebbie, Burrows — treats the studio as a micro-commons rather than a hierarchy of author and illustrator. Blake's maxim from *Jerusalem* states the alternative with which the corpus confronts its readers: one must create a system or be enslaved by another's. Enclosure is the enslavement of the imagination to another's system; creation is its liberation.

Two tensions remain, and they will be resolved in Chapter 11. The first is that Moore's defence of the commons coexists with a robust assertion of authorial moral rights: he objects not only to the extraction of profit from his creations but to their alteration by others. The distinction that resolves the tension is between use and extraction — between the free circulation of an idea and its capture for exclusive profit against the integrity of the work and the will of its makers. The second tension is that Moore's own use of public-domain characters is frequently transformative and sometimes violent; the commons, too, can be abused. Both tensions point toward the ethics of representation that the thesis will ultimately

propose.

II

4 The Overman and the Abyss

5 Persona

6 The Architecture of Atrocity

7 The Tree and the Archive

8 The Heart of England

9 The Lovecraft Inversion

Part Two

The Corpus



The Overman and the Abyss

Miracleman, Watchmen, *and the Political Theology of the Superhero*

Moore's superhero fiction is a sustained inquiry into a single question: what happens to ethics, politics, and time when a being exists for whom the ordinary limits of human agency do not apply? Carl Schmitt's *Politische Theologie* (1922) opened with the definition that frames the inquiry: "Souverän ist, wer über den Ausnahmezustand entscheidet" — sovereign is he who decides on the exception. The superhero is the Schmittian sovereign embodied: the one who suspends the law in order to save it. This chapter argues that Moore's superhero work proceeds from a Nietzschean posing of the question in *Miracleman*, through its multiversal displacement in *Captain Britain*, to its dissection into four irreconcilable ethics in *Watchmen*, and finally to a series of attempted repairs in the 1990s.

4.1 *Marvelman* and the Nietzschean Problem

Moore acknowledged that his revival of Mick Anglo's *Marvelman*, begun with Garry Leach and Alan Davis in *Warrior* in 1982, was conceived as a serious counterpart to Harvey Kurtzman and Wally Wood's parody "Superduperman!" (*Mad* #4, 1953): it would do in earnest what Kurtzman had done for laughs, by asking what a superman would actually be and what he would actually do. The literary precursors of the question are Philip Wylie's *Gladiator* (1930), whose superhuman protagonist finds no place in human society, and Olaf Stapledon's *Odd John* (1935), whose superhuman community chooses extinction over coexistence. Its philosophical source is Friedrich Nietzsche's *Also sprach Zarathustra* (1883–85), in which humanity is defined as a transition: "Der Mensch ist ein Seil, geknüpft zwischen Thier und Übermensch, — ein Seil über einem Abgrunde" — man is a rope, tied between beast and overman — a rope over an abyss.

Moore makes the Nietzschean source explicit. Mike Moran, a middle-aged freelance journalist, recovers the magic word that transforms him into Marvelman and discovers that the cheerful adventures of his 1950s youth were never real: they were virtual experiences implanted by the scientist Emil Gargunza under a British government programme named Project Zarathustra. The innocence of the Silver Age superhero is revealed as a manufactured dream, an enclosure of consciousness by the state. The genre's founding naïveté is not merely outgrown; it is exposed as an instrument of control.

The work then pursues the overman to his conclusions in two directions. The first is corporeal. In *Miracleman* #9 (1986) the birth of Moran's daughter is depicted with obstetric explicitness, an intrusion of the human body into a genre built on the body's transcendence; the child, Winter, will be the first post-human. The second is apocalyptic. In #15 (1988), drawn by John Totleben, Miracleman's former sidekick, Kid Miracleman, freed from all restraint, devastates London in a sequence of atrocities rendered with a specificity unprecedented in the genre. The issue is the corpus's first full encounter with *horror pleni*: the panels hold each death permanently, and the reader cannot look away from a page on which everything is simultaneously present.

The third book, "Olympus" (#11–16), imagines the aftermath. Miracleman and his allies abolish money, war, and crime, and rule humanity as benevolent gods from a palace raised over the ruins of London. Moore refuses to resolve his ambivalence. The utopia is a genuine fulfilment of human hopes and a totalitarian foreclosure of human agency; the gods decide, and history ends. The work stands

in a line with Arthur C. Clarke's *Childhood's End* (1953), in which benevolent alien Overlords preside over the end of humanity as the children transcend into a collective Overmind. In both, the arrival of the higher being is the end of the human, and the reader is left uncertain whether to call the end transfiguration or extinction. Neil Gaiman's continuation, *The Golden Age*, would explore the lives of ordinary people under the gods; Moore's portion ends at the summit, where the overman has crossed the abyss and found nothing on the other side to resist him.

4.2 *Captain Britain* and the Omniverse

Moore's run on *Captain Britain* with Alan Davis (1981–84) displaced the problem into multiversal space. Its cosmology posits an Omniverse of parallel Earths, policed by a corps of Captain Britains and threatened, in its central arc, by Mad Jim Jaspers, whose psychic power renders reality plastic to his madness, and by the Fury, an implacable cyborg built to exterminate super-beings. The arc can be read as a negative image of Ideaspace: reality made subject to a single imagination, enclosed by one deranged will. The Fury, which hunts the anomalous across realities and cannot be reasoned with, is the logic of the exception turned against itself — sovereignty without a sovereign, the extermination of every exception by an exception.

4.3 *Watchmen*: Four Ethics at the End of the World

Watchmen (with Dave Gibbons and John Higgins, 1986–87) is the most rigorous of Moore's inquiries because it refuses to embody the superhuman in a single figure. Its nine-panel grid imposes a metronomic regularity against which every variation registers, and its chapters are punctuated by the Doomsday Clock, advancing toward midnight. The work's final epigraph is Juvenal's "Quis custodiet ipsos custodes?", which Moore and Gibbons took from its use as the epigraph of the Tower Commission Report of 1987 on the Iran–Contra affair: the satirist's question about the guarding of wives had become the official epigraph of an inquiry into the secret state. Around the central question of who guards the guardians, the work distributes four ethics among four costumed figures.

Rorschach embodies deontological absolutism: the maxim *fiat justitia, et pereat mundus* — let justice be done though the world perish — taken literally. He derives, by Moore's acknowledgment, from Steve Ditko's Charlton hero The Question and Ditko's independent creation Mr. A, both expressions of Ditko's Objectivist conviction, derived from Ayn Rand, that moral reality admits no shades of grey. Moore's critique is severe — Rorschach is filthy, paranoid, and violent — but not contemptuous, and the work honours his final refusal to compromise even when compromise would preserve peace. The Comedian embodies nihilism: having seen, in Vietnam and in the secret service of the state, that the moral order is a joke, he becomes its punchline, an instrument of cruelty who laughs because nothing matters. His collapse into tears before the scale of Veidt's plan is the work's evidence that even nihilism has a limit.

Adrian Veidt, Ozymandias, embodies utilitarian technocracy. Modelling himself on Alexander and on Ramesses II, he calculates that the deaths of millions in New York will prevent the deaths of billions in nuclear war, and he manufactures the necessary catastrophe. The eleventh chapter takes its title and epigraph from Shelley's sonnet: "Look on my works, ye Mighty, and despair!" The catastrophe Veidt manufactures is, crucially, a work of art. On an island workshop he assembles artists, writers, and scientists — among them Max Shea, author of the pirate comic that runs through *Watchmen* as a text within the text — who believe they are designing a film; their imaginations are pooled into a monstrous creature whose cloned psychic brain broadcasts nightmares at the moment of its death. Veidt's apocalypse is Ideaspace weaponised: the collective imagination enclosed, conscripted, and discharged as an instrument of state terror. The pirate comic, in which a castaway who seeks to save his family from a ship of the

damned becomes as monstrous as the ship itself, glosses the plan; and the sixth chapter's epigraph, from §146 of *Jenseits von Gut und Böse* (1886), names its moral: "Wer mit Ungeheuern kämpft, mag zusehn, dass er nicht dabei zum Ungeheuer wird" — whoever fights monsters should see to it that he does not become one.

Dr Manhattan embodies the eternalist consciousness analysed in Chapter 2, and he bears a Gnostic reading. In Gnostic cosmology, as Hans Jonas reconstructed it in *The Gnostic Religion* (1958), the true God is alien to the world, which is the work of a lesser and ignorant demiurge; salvation is the recovery of knowledge of one's origin beyond it. Veidt is the demiurge, the fashioner of a false peace built on a lie; Manhattan is the alien God, who sees the whole, intervenes once, and departs to create life in another galaxy. His final exchange with Veidt, who asks whether his plan was justified "in the end," receives the eternalist's answer: nothing ends. In the block, no plan succeeds, because nothing is ever finished.

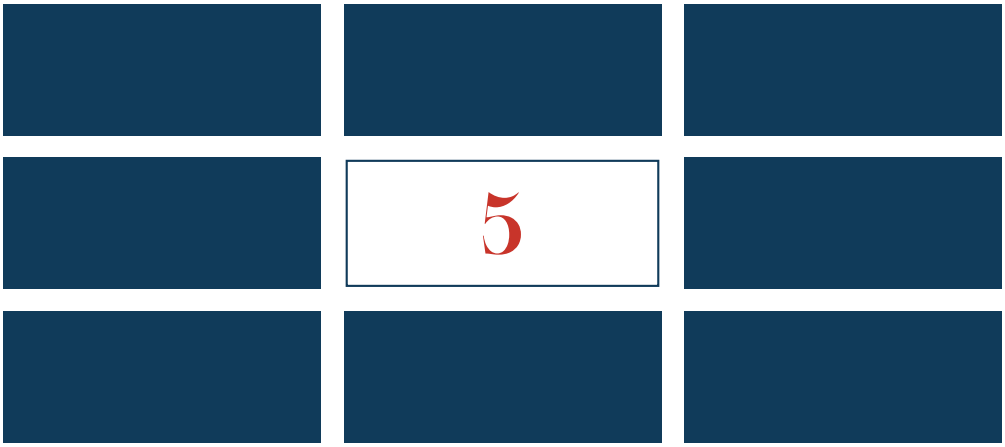
Against these four ethics stand Dan Dreiberg and Laurie Juspeczyk, who embody none: compromised, frightened, loving, and ordinary, they are the human in the gutter of the superhuman. The work's ending belongs neither to them nor to the four ethicists but to an act of reading. In the final panel, at the offices of a right-wing journal, a young assistant reaches toward the file of crank submissions in which Rorschach's journal, containing the truth of Veidt's plan, waits to be read. The future of the world depends on whether a text will be read. History, in *Watchmen*, is a contest between texts — Veidt's manufactured creature and Rorschach's journal — and the arbiter of the contest is the reader. The work's prose supplements, from the memoir of the first Nite Owl to Veidt's corporate correspondence, extend the point: *Watchmen* is an archive, and its meaning is produced by the reader's braiding of its documents.

4.4 The Revision of Revision

Moore's shorter superhero works pursue the same questions. "For the Man Who Has Everything" (*Superman Annual* #11, 1985, with Gibbons) traps Superman in a parasitic plant's fantasy of the ordinary life he never had — fulfilment as a prison, an early figure of the enclosed imagination. "Whatever Happened to the Man of Tomorrow?" (1986, with Curt Swan) closes the Silver Age Superman with a preface reminding readers that this is an imaginary story — and that so, after all, are the others. *Batman: The Killing Joke* (1988, with Brian Bolland) gives the Joker a theory of contingency, that a single bad day separates sanity from madness, and has him cripple Barbara Gordon to prove it; Moore later expressed regret for the work and particularly for its treatment of her, which became a central exhibit in the critique of the genre's disposal of women that Gail Simone's "Women in Refrigerators" list (1999) made visible. Chapter 8 will argue that *Jerusalem* is Moore's philosophical refutation of the Joker's thesis.

The 1990s works attempt repair. *1963* (1993) pastiched the early Marvel style with affection and irony. *Supreme* (1996–2000) introduced the Supremacy, a limbo inhabited by every discarded version of the character produced by successive revisions of continuity — an afterlife of obsolete drafts and the first explicit version of Mansoul. *Tom Strong* (1999–2006, with Chris Sprouse) recovered the pulp science-hero's optimism as a deliberate counterweight to the grimness Moore believed *Watchmen* had licensed. And "What We Can Know About Thunderman," in *Illuminations* (2022), returned to the industry itself as a morality play of exploitation, settling accounts with the culture that had shaped and enclosed him.

The result is not a rejection of the superhero but a demonstration of its theological structure. The superhero is the sovereign exception; Moore's corpus shows that the exception, once admitted, devours the order it claims to protect. His alternative, developed in *V for Vendetta* and *Top 10*, is not a better sovereign but the abolition of sovereignty — though, as Chapter 5 shows, the anarchist hero is himself an exception, and the problem recurs at every level of the corpus.



Persona

Masks, Puppets, and Vegetable Gods in Swamp Thing *and* V for Vendetta

Moore's characters are, again and again, roles that outlast their bearers. A plant believes itself a man; a man becomes an idea; a severed head speaks from a spike; a puppet is a god; a story incarnates in whoever writes it. This chapter argues that these figures compose a single anthropology, in which the person is a *persona* — a role through which a voice sounds — and in which the role, lodged in Ideaspace, is ontologically prior to the body that wears it. The anthropology is the comics character's mode of being generalised to human beings, and it supplies the ethical foundation for the politics of Chapter 3.

5.1 ``The Anatomy Lesson'' and the Vegetable Cogito

Moore's first issue of substance on *Saga of the Swamp Thing* (#21, 1984, with Stephen Bissette and John Totleben) is a philosophical coup. Its title recalls Rembrandt's *The Anatomy Lesson of Dr Nicolaes Tulp* (1632), and its procedure is an autopsy. Jason Woodrue, dissecting the creature's body for a corporation that wishes to exploit it, discovers that Swamp Thing is not the scientist Alec Holland transformed by his bio-restorative formula, as the series had held for a decade. Holland died in the swamp. The vegetation that absorbed his remains, saturated with the formula, also absorbed his memories and organised itself into a body that believed itself to be him. Swamp Thing is a plant that thought it was a man.

The revelation inverts the Cartesian cogito. The creature thinks, and therefore is; but what it thinks it is, it is not. Identity, on the model of John Locke's memory criterion, follows the memories; the substrate is indifferent. The precedent in fiction is Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein; or, The Modern Prometheus* (1818), whose creature is a composite body in search of a self; the precedent in philosophy is the paradox of the Ship of Theseus. But Moore's resolution is neither Lockean nor Shelleyan. The creature does not discover that it is no one; it discovers that it is a pattern — a persona — that can be borne by any material, and it chooses to continue bearing it. The comics character, which survives changes of artist, writer, and even ontology, is here made the image of a self.

The pattern belongs to a larger one. In the Brazilian rainforest Swamp Thing meets the Parliament of Trees (#47, 1986), the rooted assembly of his predecessors, earlier plant elementals who have withdrawn into contemplation of the Green, the planetary field of vegetable consciousness of which each elemental is a temporary avatar. The Green anticipates James Lovelock's Gaia (1979) as a mythic image and Ideaspace as a metaphysical one: a collective mind of which individuals are expressions. The Parliament's quietism — its withdrawal from history into communion — is the green counterpart of Dr Manhattan's detachment, and Swamp Thing's refusal to join it is the first statement of the corpus's suspicion of transcendence as escape.

5.2 Eros, Horror, and the Integration of Contraries

"Rite of Spring" (#34, 1985) renders the sexual union of Swamp Thing and Abby Arcane through a tuber he grows from his body, which she eats: a vegetal sacrament that opens her perception to the Green and dissolves the boundary between species. Bissette and Totleben abandon conventional panels for floating, interpenetrating images. The issue is a literalisation of Blake's dictum in *The Marriage of Heaven and Hell*: "If the doors of perception were cleansed every thing would appear to man as it is, infinite." When the relationship is later exposed in a photograph, Abby is arrested in Gotham City for crimes against nature (#51–53), and Swamp Thing responds by overgrowing the city until the law relents: the law's enclosure of love answered by the commons of vegetable life reclaiming the city.

The "American Gothic" sequence (#37–50) introduced John Constantine (#37, 1985), a working-class English magician of punk extraction whose manipulations of others make him Moore's critical self-portrait of the magus. The sequence turns horror into social anatomy: toxic waste in "Nukeface" (#35–36); the patriarchal mythologisation of the female body in "The Curse" (#40), where lycanthropy becomes the curse of a woman's body in a suburb that treats menstruation as pollution; the ghosts of slavery possessing a television production on a former plantation (#41–42); and, in "Ghost Dance" (#45), a house perpetually extended to placate the ghosts of those killed by the rifles that made its owner's fortune — the Winchester Mystery House transposed into a parable of American gun violence, and architecture made the permanent record of atrocity.

The sequence culminates in a cosmological crisis. The primordial Darkness, older than creation, ascends to confront the Presence, God; the gathered magicians and heroes of the DC universe prepare for a final war of light and dark. In "The Summoning" (#50, 1986) no war occurs. The Darkness, having been shown the nature of good through the eyes of Swamp Thing, rises to meet the Presence, and the two merge in an image of complementarity. The cosmic dualism of Zoroastrian and Manichaean tradition, in which good and evil are opposed substances destined for a final battle, is replaced by Blake's doctrine of contraries — "Without Contraries is no progression" — by the Taoist complementarity of yin and yang, and by the late Jung's argument in *Answer to Job* (1952) that the divine must integrate its shadow. The superhero genre's narrative engine, the war of good against evil, is dissolved into integration. Evil is not defeated; it is understood.

The parable of authorship that closes Moore's run makes the ethics explicit.

In "My Blue Heaven" (#56, 1987), exiled on an alien world of blue vegetation, Swamp Thing fashions a replica of Abby and a replica of the world he has lost, and then, recognising the lifelessness of a world composed entirely of himself, destroys it. The episode is a fable of solipsistic creation. A world in which the beloved is the author's own image is a prison, not a paradise — the same lesson as the parasitic plant's fantasy in "For the Man Who Has Everything." Creation, in Moore's ethics, must produce genuine otherness, or it is enclosure.

5.3 The Mask and the Idea

In *V for Vendetta* the persona achieves its purest form. V's face is never seen; his name is a Roman numeral and the number of his cell; his past is reconstructed only through the diary of a camp doctor; and when Evey finds him dead, she chooses not to remove the mask. V has told his executioners, in substance, that there is no flesh beneath the cloak to kill — only an idea, and ideas cannot be shot. Evey's assumption of the mask confirms the claim. The persona passes from one body to another, as the comics character passes from artist to artist, and the transfer is the political act on which the work ends. V's body, meanwhile, receives a Viking's funeral in a train packed with explosives and sent beneath Downing Street.

The Latin *persona* was derived by the grammarian Gavius Bassus, as reported by Aulus Gellius, from *personare*, to sound through: the theatrical mask through which the actor's voice resounds. Modern philology prefers an Etruscan origin, but the folk etymology is Moore's: the mask is the instrument through which a voice speaks that is larger than its wearer. The Guy Fawkes mask itself derives from the effigies burned on Bonfire Night, and the Gunpowder Plot it commemorates was, as Chapter 3 noted, substantially a Northamptonshire conspiracy.

Voice of the Fire makes the connection explicit. Its chapter set in 1607 is narrated by the severed head of the plotter Francis Tresham, displayed in Northampton, and is titled "Confessions of a Mask" — the title of Yukio Mishima's 1949 novel of a self composed of performed normality. The head is a mask without a wearer, a persona surviving the body it once animated. The same novel recounts, through its November motifs, the "blazing car" murder committed near Hardingstone on the night following Bonfire Night in 1930, in which Alfred Arthur Rouse burned a stranger in his car in an attempt to stage his own death and begin a new life: a man who sought to make a corpse into his mask. Fire, masks, Bonfire Night, and

the forging of identity braid the novel's millennia together, and they link it, across Moore's career, to the masked anarchist of *V for Vendetta*.

5.4 Faces That Are Masks

The pattern recurs throughout the corpus. In *Watchmen* Walter Kovacs calls Rorschach's mask, with its shifting black-and-white blot, his face; the man beneath is the disguise. In *From Hell*, as Chapter 6 shows, William Gull is a man while "Jack the Ripper" is a persona invented by the press, and it is the persona, not the man, that persists through the following century. In *Promethea*, as Chapter 7 shows, the heroine is a story that incarnates in whoever writes her, and Sophie Bangs becomes Promethea by composing a poem. Glycon, as Chapter 1 showed, is a puppet who is a god. And Moore himself, with the beard, rings, and staged solemnity of the Northampton wizard, has constructed a public persona of deliberate theatricality, while the reprints of *Miracleman* replace his name with the anonymous epithet "The Original Writer" — a persona without a face, imposed upon him.

Erving Goffman's *The Presentation of Self in Everyday Life* (1956) analysed social life as performance, and Jung described the persona as the mask the ego presents to the collective. Moore's position is more radical than either. For Goffman, the performance is a social fact about an individual; for Jung, the persona is a partial and potentially pathological covering of the self. For Moore, the role is ontologically prior: it is a being in Ideaspace that bodies come to bear, and it can survive any particular bearer. Human beings are, in this anthropology, characters — personae through which voices sound — and the self is not the face beneath the mask but the voice that sounds through it.

5.5 Consequences

Three consequences follow. The first is political. If characters are persons in Ideaspace, their ownership is not merely an economic arrangement but something closer to a captivity; the corporate control of characters becomes, in Moore's terms, a servitude of ideas. The second is ethical. If a persona can be transmitted, it can also be imposed: V's authorship of Evey, the press's invention of Jack, and the state's implantation of Marvelman's dreams are three forms of coercive persona-making. The third is metaphysical, and it opens onto the comparative argument of Chapter 10. Thomas Ligotti's fiction and his treatise *The Conspiracy Against the Human Race* (2010) also hold that human beings are puppets, and draw from it the conclusion that existence is a horror. Moore holds the same premise and draws the opposite conclusion. If we are puppets, then the hand inside us is our own and our neighbours', and the voice that speaks through us is shared. Kleist's grace, which appears in the puppet and in the god, appears in Moore at their coincidence.



The Architecture of Atrocity

From Hell, *the Fourth Dimension, and the Fractal Epistemology of History*

From Hell is the corpus's treatise on black magic, and its definition of black magic is precise: the illegitimate seizure of authorship over the world by the inscription of a myth upon bodies. Serialised from 1989 and collected in 1999, drawn by Eddie Campbell in a scratched, sooty line that refuses the glamour of the Gothic, and subtitled "being a melodrama in sixteen parts," it is also the corpus's most sustained exploration of *horror pleni* and its most rigorous reflection on the limits of historical knowledge. This chapter reads it in three registers: as a theory of the city as text, as an eternalist account of the birth of the twentieth century, and, through its second appendix, as a fractal epistemology.

6.1 The Wager of the Fiction

The premise is borrowed from Stephen Knight's *Jack the Ripper: The Final Solution* (1976), which proposed that the Whitechapel murders of 1888 were committed by the royal physician Sir William Withey Gull, with the coachman John Netley, to silence a group of women who knew of a secret marriage between Prince Albert Victor and a Catholic shop assistant, and that the crimes were shielded by Freemasonry. Moore states in the work's annotations that he does not believe Knight's theory. He adopts it as a scaffold: a fiction capacious enough to carry a true account of the structures — patriarchal, imperial, industrial, journalistic — within which the actual murders occurred. The wager of *From Hell* is that a false explanation can transmit a true diagnosis, which is the wager of all of Moore's fiction and, in Chapter 1's terms, of magic itself.

The annotations, which run to dozens of pages, and the second appendix, discussed below, make the wager visible. The work exhibits its sources, marks its inventions, and discloses its scepticism, so that the reader experiences the fiction and its critique at once. Few historical fictions so thoroughly expose their own machinery, and the exposure is a formal argument: the work insists that history is something constructed and read, and that its construction is a moral act.

6.2 Chapter Four: The City as Codex

The fourth chapter is the work's philosophical centre. Gull directs Netley on a carriage journey through London, stopping at sites whose significance he expounds in a lecture of hypnotic erudition: the reputed resting place of Boudicca near Battle Bridge, Nicholas Hawksmoor's churches, Cleopatra's Needle on the Embankment, Bunhill Fields where Blake lies buried, and others. Plotted on a map, the sites trace a pentagram over the city. Gull's thesis is that London's architecture encodes a historical war of principles: an ancient lunar, feminine, and chthonic order subdued by a solar, masculine, and rational one, whose victory is commemorated in obelisks, churches, and monuments and whose reign must be periodically renewed by sacrifice. The murders he is about to commit will be such a renewal.

The sources are explicit. Iain Sinclair's *Lud Heat* (1975) had proposed an occult geometry linking Hawksmoor's churches, and Peter Ackroyd's *Hawksmoor* (1985) had made the architect a sacrificing magus. Gull's history of the solar overthrow of the lunar draws on J. J. Bachofen's *Das Mutterrecht* (1861), the founding text of the theory of a primordial matriarchy, and on Robert Graves's *The White Goddess* (1948); his sacrificial logic draws on James Frazer's *The Golden Bough* (1890); his architectural mysticism draws on the Masonic legend of the Dionysian Artificers. Psychogeography — from Thomas De Quincey's opium wanderings through Arthur Machen's *The London Adventure* (1924) to the Situationist *dérive* theorised by Guy Debord (1956) — supplies the method: the city is read as a text whose layout encodes desire and power.

Moore's handling of this material is double, and the doubleness is the chapter's achievement. He grants Gull's mythic history its full rhetorical force: the lecture is seductive, the correspondences uncanny, the erudition genuine. And he marks the history unmistakably as Gull's — the narrative a patriarchal intelligence tells about its own victory over a feminine principle it has itself invented in order to justify domination. Feminist historians, notably Cynthia Eller in *The Myth of Matriarchal Prehistory* (2000), would later argue that the matriarchal golden age is a modern myth with no secure archaeological basis and with ambiguous political uses; *From Hell* anticipates the critique by placing the myth in the mouth of a murderer. The matriarchal prehistory is not a lost truth but the founding fiction of the order that destroys women.

The chapter therefore yields this thesis's definition of black magic. Gull reads the city as a codex and then writes into it, using women's bodies as his page. The

Ripper murders are an inscription: a myth of solar domination written in blood on the bodies of the poorest women in London. Black magic is the illegitimate seizure of authorship — the conversion of other persons into the material of one's own text. It is the most extreme form of enclosure in the corpus: not the fencing of land or the ownership of characters, but the appropriation of human beings as the medium of another's myth.

6.3 The Fourth Dimension and the Birth of the Twentieth Century

Gull's magic presupposes the eternalism of Chapter 2. He believes, with the Hintons, that time is a dimension through which acts reverberate, and that an act of sufficient intensity can be inscribed in it permanently. During the murder of Mary Kelly, in the tenth chapter, the belief is vindicated in the work's most famous sequence: Gull, in a state of ecstatic exaltation, glimpses the late twentieth century — an office, its workers indifferent and numbed, a television — and understands that he has helped to bring it into being. The Ripper is the obstetrician of the century.

Moore has stated in interviews that the twentieth century was in a meaningful sense born in Whitechapel in 1888, and *From Hell* specifies the claim. The murders inaugurated the sensational mass-media event, the serial killer as cultural form, the industrial and administrative detachment from suffering that the century would perfect, and the commodification of horror as entertainment. Their most consequential product was a name. The "Dear Boss" letter of September 1888, signed "Jack the Ripper," is widely believed to have been concocted by a journalist, and *From Hell* follows that view. The press invented the persona; the persona outlived the murderer. Gull is a man; "Jack" is an entity of Ideaspace, a god born of newsprint. In the terms of Chapter 5, the Ripper is the corpus's darkest persona: a mask manufactured by the gutter press and worn, ever since, by imitators and by the culture that consumes them.

The fourteenth chapter, "Gull, Ascending," follows Gull's consciousness after death through time. Unmoored from sequence, he moves among the coming century's killers and visionaries; in one of the work's boldest conceits he is glimpsed by William Blake, and the apparition becomes Blake's visionary head *The Ghost of a Flea* (c. 1819–20). The sequence is *horror pleni* in its purest form. In the block, the murderer's act does not end. It persists as an archetype in Ideaspace, propa-

gated by imitation and by the culture of fascination, so that the murders of 1888 are permanently occurring and permanently reproduced.

Yet the work also contains its quiet counter-movement. Among the visions of Gull's last chapter is a suggestion that the woman butchered in Miller's Court may not have been Mary Kelly at all — that Kelly herself escaped to Ireland and lived to raise children. The suggestion cannot be confirmed within the work, and its uncertainty is the point. Within the block, which Gull believed he had mastered, there remains a story outside the magus's script, a life he could not inscribe. The gutter keeps its own story. This is the first appearance of *gloria pleni* against the darkest background in the corpus.

6.4 The Dance of the Gull-Catchers: A Fractal Epistemology

The second appendix, "The Dance of the Gull-Catchers," drawn by Campbell in a looser comic register, narrates the history of Ripperology itself: the century of investigators, theorists, and cranks who have pursued the case, each catching a different gull. Moore frames the history with an analogy from mathematics. The Koch snowflake, constructed by repeatedly adding smaller triangles to the sides of a triangle, has a perimeter that grows without limit while enclosing a finite area. Benoit Mandelbrot's "How Long Is the Coast of Britain?" (1967) showed that coastlines behave the same way: the finer the measurement, the longer the coast. The Ripper case, Moore argues, is a fractal. Its boundary of detail expands infinitely with every new investigation, while the area it encloses — five murders in a few streets in a few weeks — remains finite. No investigation can close it.

The analogy constitutes an epistemology. Historical knowledge, on this account, is not convergent but fractal: each increase in resolution generates new detail, new connection, new hypothesis, without approaching closure. It is also a statement of the central axiom. Every fragment of history, examined closely enough, contains structures as complex as the whole, so that any event — five murders in Whitechapel — can serve as an Aleph of its century. Moore's unfinished *Big Numbers* (1990, with Bill Sienkiewicz), which applied chaos mathematics and the Mandelbrot set to the redevelopment of a provincial English town by an American shopping-mall company, attempted the same method on the present; its abandonment after two issues seems, in retrospect, almost structural to a fractal subject.

The epistemology entails a critique of conspiracy theory. Moore has argued repeatedly that conspiracy theories are, at bottom, consoling: they assume that someone is in control, and so protect their believers from the more frightening truth that no one is — that the world is driven by unsteered forces. *From Hell* uses a conspiracy as its scaffold while denying that conspiracy is the truth. The structures it diagnoses are not secret agents but systems — patriarchy, empire, capital, the press — whose effects require no conspirators. Mark Fisher's *The Weird and the Eerie* (2016) names the affect of such systems. The eerie, for Fisher, arises from a failure of absence or of presence that raises the question of agency: who or what is acting here? Capital is, in Fisher's account, an eerie entity, exerting force without ever being present. *From Hell* is eerie in exactly this sense: its true agent is a structure that no one controls.

Moore's earlier *Brought to Light* (1988, with Bill Sienkiewicz), a documentary

account of covert American operations narrated by a drunken bald eagle, establishes the necessary distinction. Moore does not deny that states conspire; *Brought to Light* documents conspiracies of record. What he denies is the metaphysical conspiracy — the belief that a hidden will governs history as a whole. Umberto Eco's *Foucault's Pendulum* (1988), in which three editors invent a universal conspiracy as a game and are destroyed by believers who take it literally, satirises the same temptation, and Eco's *The Limits of Interpretation* (1990) diagnoses its method as hermetic semiosis: the drift from correspondence to correspondence without end. Moore is a hermeticist who has learned Eco's lesson. He uses correspondence as a creative method while refusing to let it close into a single plan. The Gull-catchers dance forever because the coast of history is infinitely long.



7

The Tree and the Archive

Promethea, The League of Extraordinary Gentlemen, *and the Literary Commons*

Promethea and *The League of Extraordinary Gentlemen*, launched within months of each other in 1999, are complementary theories of the imaginal commons. *Promethea* is vertical: a curriculum of ascent through Ideaspace, culminating in the opening of the imaginal realm to all. The *League* is horizontal: an archive of every fiction ever written, laid out as a single coexisting world. One teaches how to enter Ideaspace; the other maps it. Together they constitute the corpus's most explicit statement that the imagination is a common territory, and its most explicit warning about what enclosure does to the beings who live there.

7.1 *Promethea*: The Story That Incarnates

Promethea (1999–2005), drawn by J. H. Williams III with Mick Gray, is Moore's most openly didactic work, and its didacticism is formal as much as discursive. Its heroine originates in Alexandria in 411 CE, as the daughter of a pagan scholar murdered by a Christian mob — an episode that recalls the killing of Hypatia in the same city four years later and stages the destruction of late-antique Hermetic learning as the work's primal scene. Rescued by Thoth and Hermes, the girl passes into the Immateria, Ideaspace rendered as a landscape, and becomes a story. Thereafter Promethea incarnates in whoever writes, draws, or imagines her with sufficient intensity: a poet at the turn of the twentieth century, a pulp-era illustrator, a male comic artist, the wife of a science-hero. In an alternate New York of 1999, a student named Sophie Bangs, researching the Promethea legend for a paper, becomes the latest incarnation by writing a poem.

The names are a programme. *Sophie* is Sophia, the divine Wisdom of Hellenistic Judaism and the fallen Aeon of Gnostic myth, who descends into the world and must be redeemed; the Simonian tradition identified her with Ennoia, the first Thought of God, incarnated in the woman Helen. *Promethea* feminises Prometheus, the thief of fire, and invokes both Mary Shelley's *Modern Prometheus* and Percy Shelley's lyrical drama *Prometheus Unbound* (1820), in which the liberation of the Titan coincides with his reunion with Asia, the feminine principle of love, and with the renovation of the cosmos. The previous Promethea, Barbara Shelley, carries the poets' surname. The heroine is a feminine Logos: a divine idea that becomes flesh through writing.

The work's middle section is a Hermetic curriculum. Issue #12 compresses a cosmogony, a history of the world, and the twenty-two trumps of the Tarot into a single sequence of pages, drawing on Crowley's Thoth deck and the Waite–Smith tradition and layering image with verse and wordplay. Issues #13–23 follow Sophie and Barbara through the ten sephiroth of the Kabbalistic Tree of Life, from Malkuth, the material kingdom, through Yesod, Hod, Netzach, Tiphareth, Geburah, and Chesed, across the abyss of Daath, to Binah, Chokmah, and Kether, the crown. Williams alters the visual grammar of each issue — palette, page architecture, mode of rendering — to embody the sphere it depicts, so that the reader's passage through the issues is itself an initiatory ascent. Issue #10, "Sex, Stars and Serpents," frames a sexual encounter between Promethea and the shabby magician Jack Faust as a lesson in the Tantric and Thelemic doctrine of sexuality as a ladder of consciousness.

The Kabbalah of *Promethea* is the Hermetic Qabalah of the Golden Dawn, Crowley, and Dion Fortune's *The Mystical Qabalah* (1935), not the rabbinic Kabbalah reconstructed historically by Gershom Scholem in *Major Trends in Jewish Mysticism* (1941). Its correspondences — Tarot trumps assigned to paths, planets to spheres, colours to scales — are Victorian systematisations, and its ascent is psychologised as a map of consciousness rather than practised within a religious community. The critique of decontextualised appropriation applies, and this thesis registers it in Chapter 11. But Moore uses the Tree as a curriculum rather than as a doctrine: a diagram of the imagination's possible states, offered to every reader.

The final movement (#24–32) brings the apocalypse. Its meaning is etymological. The Greek *apokalypsis* means uncovering, and Promethea's end of the world is the lifting of the veil between the material world and the Immateria, so that every human being experiences the world as at once physical and imaginal, story and substance. The world does not end; a mode of perception ends. The vision belongs to the modern family of eschatologies of consciousness: Teilhard de Chardin's Omega Point, Terence McKenna's eschaton, and Moore's own "boiling point" hypothesis, set out in *The Mindscape of Alan Moore*, which extrapolates the accelerating doubling of human information — the calculations associated with the economist Georges Anderla and popularised by Robert Anton Wilson as the "Jumping Jesus" phenomenon — toward a phase transition, a culture boiling into a new state. Ray Kurzweil's technological Singularity (2005) is the technocratic twin of this vision; Moore's version is a singularity of the imagination, requiring no machines.

The last issue enacts the apocalypse upon the object. Its pages, removed from the binding and assembled, compose two continuous images. To see the work whole, the reader must dismantle the codex and convert sequence into simultaneity — must perform, on the book, the transition from character to reader that *Jerusalem* will describe as death. And because the apocalypse absorbs the whole America's Best Comics universe, it also performs, as Chapter 3 argued, the authorial closure of a fictional world against the franchise's demand for perpetual continuation.

7.2 The *League*: An Atlas of All Fictions

The League of Extraordinary Gentlemen (1999–2019, with Kevin O'Neill) begins as an adventure pastiche — a team assembled in 1898 from Victorian fiction: Mina Murray from Stoker's *Dracula*, Allan Quatermain from Haggard, Captain Nemo from Verne, Jekyll and Hyde from Stevenson, Hawley Griffin from Wells's *The Invisible Man* — and becomes, volume by volume, an atlas of the totality of fiction. The second volume pits the League against the Martians of Wells's *The War of the Worlds* and appends "The New Traveller's Almanac," a prose gazetteer locating the fictional places of world literature on a single globe. *The Black Dossier* (2007) adds pastiches of Shakespearean drama, Cleland, Kerouac, and the Tijuana bible, and concludes with a three-dimensional sequence in the Blazing World. *Century* (2009–12) follows the immortal League through 1910, 1969, and 2009. The *Nemo* trilogy (2013–15) and *The Tempest* (2018–19) complete the cycle, and with it Moore's career in comics.

The *League* has precursors. Philip José Farmer's Wold Newton family (1972) linked the heroes of popular fiction by genealogy; Farmer's *Riverworld* novels (from 1971) resurrected all of humanity along a single river, an afterlife in which every historical person coexists; Kim Newman's *Anno Dracula* (1992) made the Victorian fictional world a single alternate history. Moore's ambition is broader than any of these. The *League* posits that every story ever told is true within a single world, so that the world of the series is Ideaspace given a geography.

Its presiding figures are Prospero and Margaret Cavendish. Cavendish's *The Description of a New World, Called The Blazing-World* (1666), which Moore makes the realm of fiction itself, describes a world reached through the North Pole and governed by an Empress who creates further worlds in her own mind. Cavendish's epilogue claims for herself an imaginative sovereignty that takes nothing from anyone: "though I cannot be Henry the Fifth, or Charles the Second, yet I endeavour to be Margaret the First." The claim defines the author's legitimate sovereignty — rule over a world one has made, enclosing no one else's ground. Shakespeare's Prospero, the magus who renounces his art, presides over the Blazing World in the *League*, and his renunciation will frame Moore's own. The immortals of the series — Orlando, who changes sex across centuries as in Virginia Woolf's novel; and Mina and Allan, rejuvenated in the life-giving flame of Haggard's *She* — are those who have bathed in fiction's source.

7.3 The Legal Shadow: What Enclosure Does to Characters

The most original argument the *League* makes about the commons is made through its legal constraints. Because the series is built from the public domain, characters still under copyright can appear only obliquely — unnamed, disguised, or deformed. In *The Black Dossier* a thinly veiled version of Ian Fleming's secret agent appears as a brutal thug and sexual predator called Jimmy. In the 2009 volume of *Century* the Antichrist, long sought by the occultist Oliver Haddo (the Crowley figure of Somerset Maugham's *The Magician*, 1908), is revealed as an unnamed boy wizard of contemporary franchise fame, now monstrous, and Mina's rescuer is an unnamed magical nanny descending from the sky.

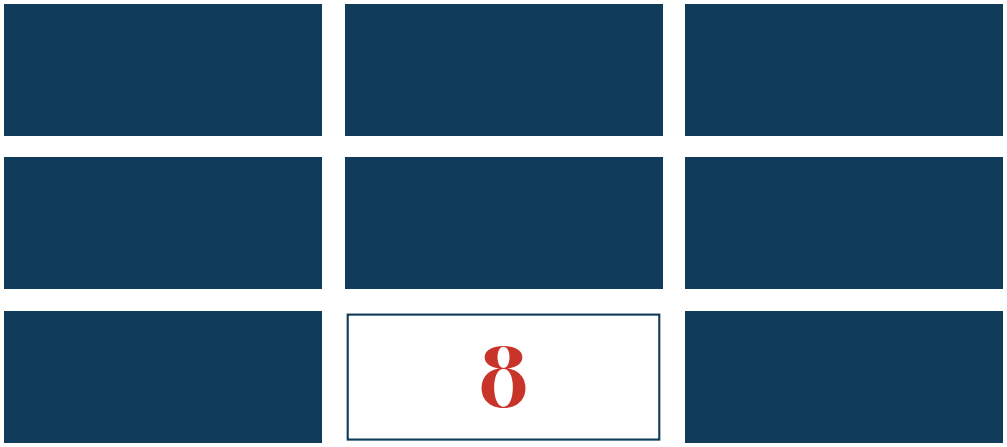
Critics have read these portraits as satire or as personal animus. This thesis reads them as an argument. In the *League*, the characters of the commons — Mina, Orlando, Nemo's daughter Janni, Quatermain — are vital, complex, and dignified. The characters of the enclosure appear as deformed shadows: nameless, degraded, monstrous. The intellectual-property regime literally deforms the beings it holds. A character that cannot circulate cannot grow; it can only be repeated, sequelised, and merchandised until it curdles. Enclosure breeds monsters; the commons sustains life. The diagnosis of *Century*'s final volume — a culture whose imagination has been captured by franchise properties, unable to produce new myths — converges with Mark Fisher's account, in *Ghosts of My Life* (2014), of the "slow cancellation of the future." Even Iain Sinclair's time-displaced wanderer Andrew Norton, borrowed into *Century* as the prisoner of London, testifies to a city in which time no longer moves forward because the culture can only recycle.

The series ends with *The Tempest*, its title and frame taken from Shakespeare's late play and its final movement explicitly a farewell — to the *League*, to comics, and to the industry. Prospero's renunciation speech supplies the image: "And deeper than did ever plummet sound / I'll drown my book." The Conclusion of this thesis returns to the drowned book.

The *League* is not innocent of the violence it diagnoses. Its first volumes include sexual assault committed by Griffin and Hyde's retributive rape of Griffin, scenes many readers have found gratuitous; the commons, too, can be used to degrade. The tension is taken up in Chapter 9's account of the representational antinomy.

7.4 *Top 10* and the Diffusion of Power

A third America's Best Comics title completes the argument from the side of politics. *Top 10* (1999–2001, with Gene Ha and Zander Cannon) is a police procedural set in Neopolis, a city in which everyone — police, criminals, taxi drivers, children — has superpowers or science-hero equipment. In such a city the superhuman is mundane, and the sovereign exception has nowhere to stand. *Top 10* is the anarchist answer to *Miracleman*'s Olympus: where Olympus concentrates power in a few gods and ends history, Neopolis diffuses it among everyone and returns history to ordinary negotiation. When everyone is extraordinary, no one is sovereign. The commons of power, like the commons of imagination, is the corpus's alternative to the exception.



8

The Heart of England

Voice of the Fire, Jerusalem, The Great When, *and the Afterlife of Everything*

Moore's prose fiction relocates the sacred from the metropolis and the cosmos to a single provincial town, and from the town to its poorest district. *Voice of the Fire* (1996) and *Jerusalem* (2016) form a diptych: the first descends through six thousand years of a single place; the second ascends from that place into an afterlife built on its plan. Together they give paginal eternalism its fullest statement and its most complete eschatology. This chapter reads them as an account of the sacred centre, of layered time, and of death as readership, and then considers the turn to London's imaginal double in *The Great When* (2024).

8.1 The Navel: Northampton as *Axis Mundi*

Moore was born in Northampton in 1953, grew up in its Boroughs — the district of poor terraced streets below the medieval town centre — and has lived in the town all his life. His fiction treats this fidelity not as provincialism but as metaphysics. Northampton possesses, in the Church of the Holy Sepulchre, one of the few surviving medieval round churches in England, founded around 1100 by Simon de Senlis, Earl of Northampton, after his return from the First Crusade and modelled on the rotunda of the Holy Sepulchre in Jerusalem. The identification of Northampton with Jerusalem is therefore not Moore's conceit but the town's own architecture. At Hardingstone, on the town's southern edge, stands one of the three surviving original Eleanor Crosses, raised in the 1290s to mark a resting place of Queen Eleanor's funeral procession: a permanent monument to a single night.

Mircea Eliade argued, in *Le Mythe de l'éternel retour* (1949) and *The Sacred and the Profane* (1957), that in archaic religion every sacred site is the centre of the world, the *axis mundi* where heaven, earth, and underworld meet, so that there can be as many centres as there are sanctuaries. Jorge Luis Borges's "El Aleph" (1945) located the point containing all points in a cellar in a dull Buenos Aires street. Moore's central axiom combines the two. Every place is the centre; the Boroughs are the navel of England not by exception but by example. Blake's preface to *Milton* had asked whether Jerusalem was builded here, and had vowed: "I will not cease from Mental Fight, / Nor shall my Sword sleep in my hand: / Till we have built Jerusalem, / In Englands green & pleasant Land." Moore relocates the building site from the green and pleasant land to the slum at the bottom of the hill.

This is a deliberate correction of metropolitan psychogeography. Iain Sinclair and Peter Ackroyd made London the privileged palimpsest of English time; Moore insists that the provincial and the working-class are as dense with time as the capital. The comparison is with Thomas Hardy's Wessex, James Joyce's Dublin, and above all Alan Garner's Alderley Edge — local places treated as the whole world.

8.2 *Voice of the Fire*: Six Thousand Years in One Place

Voice of the Fire comprises twelve chapters set in and around Northampton, from 4000 BCE to 1995, each narrated in a different voice and idiom. Its opening chapter, "Hob's Hog," is narrated by a Neolithic boy in a constrained idiolect in which the distinctions between dream and waking, self and landscape, and past and present have not yet stabilised. The precedents are William Golding's *The Inheritors* (1955), narrated from within Neanderthal consciousness, and Russell Hoban's *Riddley Walker* (1980), written in the degraded English of a post-nuclear future; Moore's later *Crossed +100* (2014–15) would invent a future dialect of its own, the inverse of Hob's prehistoric speech. The chapter also enacts what Owen Barfield called original participation and what Julian Jaynes, in *The Origin of Consciousness in the Breakdown of the Bicameral Mind* (1976), called the pre-introspective mind. The novel's history begins inside a consciousness for which the world is not yet an object.

The following chapters move through the Bronze Age, the Roman and medieval periods, the Gunpowder Plot (through the severed head of Francis Tresham), the witch trials, and the twentieth century, including the 1930 "blazing car" murder discussed in Chapter 5. The chapters are linked not by plot but by recurrent motifs: fire, severed heads, black dogs, shoes and feet, boundary-stones, forgeries, and fraudulent identities. The motifs function exactly as Groensteen's braiding functions on the comics page: non-adjacent episodes resonate across millennia, so that the town's history becomes a single braided object. The final chapter is narrated by Moore himself in 1995, so that the author enters the chain as the last voice of the fire. Authorship becomes one more layer of the palimpsest, and the writer one more of the town's speaking heads.

The novel's thesis is that a place remembers. Nigel Kneale's television play *The Stone Tape* (1972) imagined the material of a building recording the events that occurred within it; Alan Garner's *Red Shift* (1973) bound three periods of a single Cheshire landscape — Roman, Civil War, and contemporary — through a stone axe-head that passes among them. *Voice of the Fire* belongs to this tradition of layered locality, and to the British folk horror that Adam Scovell (2017) describes as moving from landscape, through isolation and skewed belief, to a summoning. But Moore removes the horror's moralism. The past in *Voice of the Fire* is not a curse that returns to punish the present; it is the present's own depth.

8.3 *Jerusalem*: The Eschatology of the Boroughs

Jerusalem, published in 2016 at more than twelve hundred pages, is Moore's summa. Its first book, "The Boroughs," recounts lives in the district across centuries; its second, "Mansoul," follows the three-year-old Michael Warren, who chokes on a cough sweet in 1959 and is briefly dead, into the afterlife; its third, "Vernall's Inquest," draws the threads together in the present. Michael and his sister Alma, an artist, are drawn from Moore and his brother; the novel's final movement centres on Alma's exhibition of paintings depicting the novel's own visions, so that the book ends by containing an image of itself.

The cosmology is precise. Mansoul — the name taken from John Bunyan's allegory *The Holy War* (1682), in which the town of Mansoul is the human soul besieged — is an upper storey of the town, a second Boroughs above the first, from which the dead survey the four-dimensional totality of the district's history and travel along it at will. Michael's guides are the Dead Dead Gang, a band of children who died young, led by Phyllis Painter, who roam eternity like J. M. Barrie's Lost Boys. Above them work the Builders, angelic architects whose game of snooker shapes the course of lives, determinism made into play. Between storeys work the Vernalls, a family whose men are charged with maintaining the edges: Ernest Vernall, who went mad in 1865 after glimpsing the Builders while restoring St Paul's Cathedral, and his son Snowy, who walks the rooftops with a serene knowledge of the whole shape of his life.

Mansoul is the democratisation of the Boethian eternity described in Chapter 2: every soul, after death, possesses its life *tota simul*. It is also the realisation of Blake's Golgonooza, the city of art built by Los, and specifically of the halls described in *Jerusalem*, plate 16: "All things acted on Earth are seen in the bright Sculptures of Los's Halls," in which every age renews its powers and every sorrow is carved. In Moore's novel, as in Blake's, nothing that has happened is lost; it is preserved, visible, and available to those who can see.

The novel's formal virtuosity serves this cosmology. Its chapters change register to match their subjects: one is written in the dense, punning idiolect of Lucia Joyce, the daughter of James Joyce, who spent her last three decades in St Andrew's Hospital in Northampton; another follows John Clare, who spent his last twenty-three years in the same institution, then called the Northampton General Lunatic Asylum; others take the forms of drama and of children's adventure fiction. The asylum emerges as the town's prophetic organ, and madness as an involuntary eternalist perception. Clare and Lucia Joyce are seers whom the town

confined, and the novel restores them as its visionaries — the enclosure of the visionary reversed by the novel's commons of voices.

8.4 Death as Readership, Judgment as Inquest

The eschatological consequence of Mansoul can now be stated in the terms of this thesis. In *Jerusalem*, the dead look down on their lives as a reader looks down on a page. The living are characters, moving through their lives in sequence, with the A-series experience of a present; the dead are readers, surveying the whole and able to enter any moment. Death is the transition from character to reader. Those who glimpse the reader's position while alive — the near-dead Michael, the mad Ernest, the serene Snowy, the confined Clare and Lucia — are those whom Chapter 11 will call visionaries; those who learn to occupy it deliberately are magicians.

The novel's ethics follow from its eschatology, and they are articulated in the title of its third book. An inquest is not a trial. It does not determine guilt or impose punishment; it establishes how a death came about. Moore substitutes for the Last Judgment a forensic eschatology: everything is seen, and nothing is sentenced. The contrast with Dante is instructive. The *Commedia*'s damned are fixed eternally in the posture of their sin, under the law of *contrapasso*; Dante's Hell is eternalism as punishment, the permanent arrest of a soul at its worst moment. C. S. Lewis's *The Great Divorce* (1945) offers the opposite Christian vision: Heaven, more solid than Earth, works backward to transform even past agony into glory. Moore accepts neither. His block does not freeze the soul at its worst moment, because the whole life is permanently present; nor does it retroactively transfigure suffering, because nothing in the block is altered. The past is neither punished nor redeemed. It is witnessed.

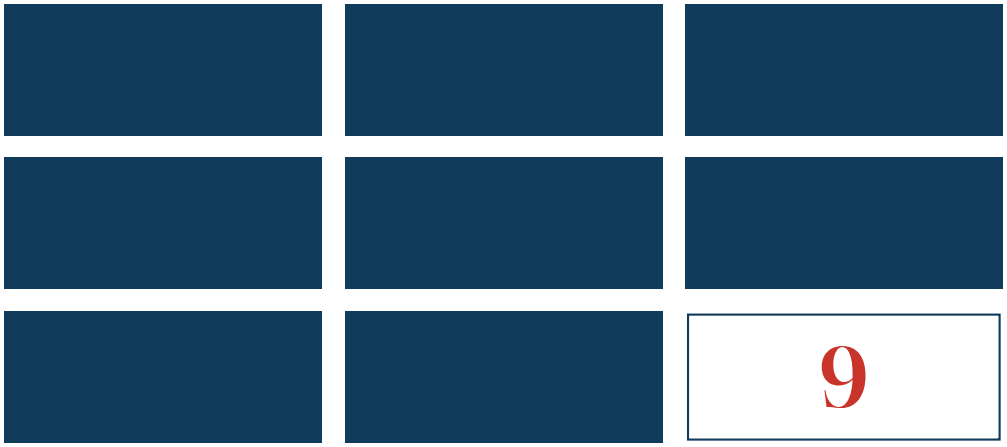
The ethical centre of this eschatology is the claim that the whole life, not any single moment, is the unit of value. This is Moore's answer to the theory of contingency his Joker proposed in *The Killing Joke*: that one bad day defines a person. In the block, no day defines a life, because every day is permanently present and the life is seen whole. The children of the Dead Dead Gang, who died young and poor, are not reduced to their deaths; their lives, seen from Mansoul, include their play, their friendships, and their eternity. The slum clearances that demolished much of the Boroughs in the 1960s and 1970s cannot erase it, because the demolished streets persist intact in the block. Stanley Spencer's *The Resurrection, Cookham* (1924–27), in which the dead rise from the graves of an English

village churchyard, is the nearest visual analogue: resurrection imagined not in Jerusalem but in the parish.

The consolation is real but not cheap. *Jerusalem* does not soften the Boroughs: poverty, violence, abuse, war, and early death persist in the block as permanently as play and love. *Horror pleni* and *gloria pleni* are the same fact seen from two sides. What the novel offers is not the erasure of suffering but its completion — the assurance that no life is only its worst moment, and that every grace, however small, is as eternal as every atrocity.

8.5 *The Great When* and Long London

The Great When (2024), the first volume of a projected *Long London* sequence, turns from Northampton to the capital and from the afterlife to the imaginal city. In the London of 1949, a young bookshop assistant, Dennis Knuckleyard, comes upon a book that should not exist and is drawn into Long London, the city's mythic double, in which London's metaphors, legends, and names take literal form. Long London is Ideaspace given an urban geography — the imaginal commons as a city, adjacent to the real one and leaking into it. It joins a tradition of imaginal Londons: Arthur Machen's *The London Adventure*, Michael Moorcock's *Mother London* (1988), Neil Gaiman's London Below in *Neverwhere* (1996), China Miéville's *King Rat* (1998) and *Kraken* (2010), and Sinclair's occult topographies. Its post-war setting, a city of rationing, ruins, and reconstruction, frames the imaginal as what survives the destruction of the material: the bombed city persists in its double, as the demolished Boroughs persist in Mansoul.



The Lovecraft Inversion

The Courtyard, Neonomicon, Providence, *and the Representational Antinomy*

Moore's Lovecraftian cycle is the dark twin of *Promethea*. Both narrate the bleeding of Ideaspace into consensus reality through acts of writing, and both end in apocalypse; they differ in the quality of the imagination that does the summoning. This chapter reads the cycle as Moore's most systematic argument that fiction builds worlds in a literal sense — and therefore as the place where his own defence of fiction's harmlessness breaks down.

9.1 Lovecraft as Symptom and Prophet

H. P. Lovecraft's essay "Supernatural Horror in Literature" (1927) opens with the creed of the weird tradition: "The oldest and strongest emotion of mankind is fear, and the oldest and strongest kind of fear is fear of the unknown." Lovecraft's cosmicism specified the unknown as cosmic indifference: a universe of vast, ancient, and alien forces in which human values are parochial accidents. "The Call of Cthulhu" (1928) then relocates the danger from ignorance to knowledge: "The most merciful thing in the world, I think, is the inability of the human mind to correlate all its contents." Lovecraft's horror is a horror of correlation. Dissociated fragments of knowledge, once joined, disclose a vista in which humanity is insignificant, and the only refuge is not to join them.

This sentence is the hinge of Moore's inversion. Moore is also a writer of correlation: the fractal history of *From Hell*, the atlas of all fictions in the *League*, and the braided millennia of *Jerusalem* are exercises in joining what appeared separate. But where correlation in Lovecraft reveals the insignificance of the human, correlation in Moore reveals its infinite significance. In the block, every life is a permanent structure and every thermodynamic miracle is preserved. The same operation produces opposite affects, and the relation between them — *horror vacui* against *horror pleni* — is generalised in Chapter 10.

Moore's introduction to Leslie S. Klinger's *The New Annotated H. P. Lovecraft* (2014) reads Lovecraft as symptom and prophet at once. Lovecraft's fears — of the alien and the hybrid, of sea and swamp, of sexuality and racial mixture, of the immigrant city, of vast time and space — were, in Moore's account, a seismograph of anxieties the twentieth century would make general. On this reading the signature adjectives of Lovecraft's prose — *nameless*, *unnameable*, *indescribable* — are not failures of style but marks of repression: what Lovecraft could not name were his own terrors. Moore's cycle sets out to name them.

9.2 *The Courtyard* and *Neonomicon*: Naming the Unnameable

The Courtyard, first published as a prose story in 1994 and adapted into comics by Antony Johnston and Jacen Burrows in 2003, introduces the cycle's central device. Aldo Sax, an FBI agent of conspicuous bigotry, investigates a series of mutilation murders and encounters Aklo — a word Lovecraft borrowed from Arthur Machen's "The White People" (1904) — reconceived as a language that rewires the perception of anyone who understands it. Aklo is magic in exactly Moore's sense: symbols that produce changes in consciousness. In *The Courtyard* it is magic as infection. Sax learns the language and becomes the killer he was hunting.

Neonomicon (2010, with Burrows) continues the story through two further agents, Merril Brears and Gordon Lamper, who interview the imprisoned Sax and then infiltrate a cult in Salem. Lamper is killed. Brears is subjected to prolonged sexual violence by the cult and by one of Lovecraft's amphibious Deep Ones, and becomes pregnant. Moore described the work as an attempt to bring into the open what Lovecraft's euphemisms concealed — the sexual terror encoded in the Innsmouth stories of interbreeding and the racial panic of "The Horror at Red Hook." Many readers have judged that the attempt reproduces, in detail and at length, the misogynist violence it claims to diagnose, and that it belongs to a broader pattern in which sexual violence against women serves the corpus as a narrative engine. The criticism is just. Its deeper significance, developed in section 9.4, is what Moore's own metaphysics implies about it.

9.3 *Providence*: Fiction as Summoning

Providence (2015–17, with Burrows) is the cycle's masterpiece and one of the most structurally ambitious works in the corpus. Robert Black, a reporter for the *New York Herald* in 1919, Jewish and secretly gay, leaves the city after a private catastrophe to research a book on the hidden occult currents of American life. His investigation follows the trail of a text, the *Kitab al-Hikmah al-Najmiyya* or "Book of Star Wisdom," and of a Hermetic fraternity, the Stella Sapiente, through a New England whose towns and inhabitants correspond, issue by issue, to the settings of Lovecraft's tales — among them "Cool Air," "The Horror at Red Hook," "The Shadow over Innsmouth," "The Dunwich Horror," "The Colour Out of Space," and "Pickman's Model." Each issue closes with pages from Black's commonplace book, in which he records his experiences in prose.

The commonplace book creates the work's governing irony: Black repeatedly fails to see what the reader sees. Confronted by the inhuman, he rationalises; offered the monstrous, he records the merely eccentric. China Miéville's *The City & The City* (2009) imagines citizens trained to "unsee" the city interleaved with their own; Black is a virtuoso of unseeing, and his unseeing is what allows the horror to proceed. The concealment his sexuality has forced on him has trained him in a discipline of not-knowing that the narrative turns against him.

The trail ends in Providence, Rhode Island, where Black meets the young H. P. Lovecraft. Black's account passes into Lovecraft's hands, and Lovecraft's fiction becomes the medium through which the beings Black failed to see enter the world's imagination. Lovecraft, in Moore's mythology, is the Herald: the writer whose stories prepare humanity to accept the mythos by making it familiar. The final issue, set in the present after the events of *Neonomicon*, shows the consequence. The world has been transformed into a Lovecraftian reality, and the most horrifying feature of the transformation is that humanity accepts it as normal. The apocalypse arrives not as destruction but as normalisation: the weird becomes ordinary because it has been so thoroughly imagined.

Providence thus states the imaginal axiom in its darkest form. Fiction is not a representation of the world but a technology for producing it, and the world becomes what its most widely read dreamers dream. The weird tradition had repeatedly reported such escapes of fiction into fact. Jorge Luis Borges's "Tlön, Uqbar, Orbis Tertius" (1940) imagines a secret society's encyclopedia of an invented world whose objects begin to appear in reality and whose doctrines displace the world's own. Machen's "The Bowmen" (1914), in which spectral archers

of Agincourt defend British soldiers at Mons, was converted by public belief into the legend of the Angels of Mons, despite Machen's protests that he had invented it. Robert W. Chambers's *The King in Yellow* (1895) imagines a play whose reading drives its readers mad. And Lovecraft's own fictional grimoire, the *Necronomicon*, acquired a material existence when a volume bearing the title and claiming authenticity was published in 1977 and adopted by occult practitioners. *Providence* turns these reports into a cosmology.

Read against *Promethea*, the twinning is exact. Both works narrate Ideaspace entering consensus reality through writing; both end in apocalypse; both make a writer — Sophie Bangs, H. P. Lovecraft — the instrument of the change. The difference lies in the imagination that summons. Promethea is summoned by a generous, plural, erotic, and syncretic imagination, and her apocalypse opens Ideaspace to everyone. The mythos of *Providence* is summoned by a fearful, purifying, and xenophobic imagination, and its apocalypse encloses the world within a single dread. The ethics of a fiction determine the world it builds.

Plato's *Republic* drew from the premise that poetry shapes souls the conclusion that poets must be censored or banished. Moore accepts the premise in its strongest form — poetry shapes not only souls but worlds — and reverses the conclusion: the remedy for bad magic is not the banishment of the magician but better magic. *Providence* belongs to a wider reckoning with Lovecraft's legacy in the 2010s. Victor LaValle's *The Ballad of Black Tom* (2016) retold "The Horror at Red Hook" from the perspective of a Black protagonist; Matt Ruff's *Lovecraft Country* (2016) made Jim Crow America the true horror of the mythos; Ruthanna Emrys's *Winter Tide* (2017) recast the people of Innsmouth as victims of state persecution; and N. K. Jemisin's *The City We Became* (2020) turned Lovecraft's cosmic enemy into a force of gentrification. Moore's contribution is distinct. Rather than inverting Lovecraft's sympathies, *Providence* enacts the mechanism by which a mythos colonises an imagination — the mechanism Chapter 3 named enclosure.

9.4 The Representational Antinomy

The Lovecraftian cycle brings to a head a contradiction that runs through Moore's ethics of representation. It can be stated as two propositions.

The first, which the whole corpus asserts, is that fictions are real. Ideas inhabit a real territory; gods and characters exist as ideas with real powers; fictions summon worlds, as *Promethea* and *Providence* both insist. A depiction therefore adds something real to the common house of the imagination.

The second, which Moore has advanced in defence of his most contested works, is that fiction is a protected space whose contents harm no one. It is stated most fully in connection with *Lost Girls* (1991–2006, with Melinda Gebbie), a long and explicitly pornographic work in which three heroines of children's literature — Lewis Carroll's Alice, J. M. Barrie's Wendy, and L. Frank Baum's Dorothy — meet as adult women at an Austrian hotel in 1913–14 and recount their sexual histories as Europe slides into war. Moore and Gebbie defended the work by insisting on a categorical distinction between fiction and reality, and by contrasting the harmlessness of the imagined with the real obscenity of the war that frames it. Moore's illustrated history *25,000 Years of Erotic Freedom* (2009) extended the argument by associating a culture's tolerance of erotic representation with its creative and intellectual vitality.

The two propositions cannot both be held. If fictions are real territories that shape consciousness and summon worlds, their contents cannot be harmless merely because they are fictional. Moore's metaphysics withdraws the very protection his defence requires. The contradiction is not confined to *Lost Girls*. It governs V's coercive authorship of Evey; the maiming of Barbara Gordon in *The Killing Joke*, which Moore came to regret; the Comedian's assault on Sally Jupiter in *Watchmen* and its later narrative reframing; the sexual violence of the *League*'s early volumes; and the protracted violation of Merril Brears in *Neonomicon*. In each case the corpus represents sexual violence with a specificity that its own premises would treat as an act within Ideaspace, while Moore's public defence of such representation treats it as inconsequential fiction.

The point at which the second proposition collapses entirely is *Lost Girls*' inclusion, within its pornographic frame, of sexual material set in its characters' childhoods, including depictions of abuse. Here the defence from fiction fails on Moore's own terms, and this thesis declines to follow it. No account of the imagination as a real and shared territory can treat the sexualised depiction of children as a harmless addition to that territory. The resolution of the antinomy — which

keeps Moore's first proposition and abandons his second — is set out in Chapter 11.

III

10
Horror Vacui, Horror Vitae, Horror Pleni

11
The Gutter and the Plenum

Part Three

Comparisons and Synthesis

10

Horror Vacui, Horror Vitae, Horror Pleni

Moore Among the Weird, the Haunted, and the Mythopoeic

Moore's place among the traditions of weird, Gothic, folk, and mythopoeic fiction is best fixed by the object of each tradition's dread. This chapter proposes three modes of cosmic dread — the horror of the void, the horror of being alive, and the horror of plenitude — and uses them to locate Moore against his precursors, his contemporaries, and his rivals. The taxonomy is heuristic rather than exhaustive, but it isolates what is distinctive in Moore: he is the only major writer in these traditions for whom the universe is terrible because it is full.

10.1 A Taxonomy of Cosmic Dread

Horror vacui is the classic mode of the weird. Its cosmos, in Lovecraft and in William Hope Hodgson's *The House on the Borderland* (1908), is vast, ancient, and indifferent; human meaning is a local accident; and knowledge is dangerous because it discloses the void around the lamplit circle of the human. The subject shrinks toward nothing, and time appears as the deep time of aeons that dwarf history.

Horror vitae is the mode of philosophical pessimism. Peter Wessel Zapffe's essay "Den sidste Messias" (1933) argued that human consciousness is a tragic overdevelopment, a faculty that exceeds what any life can bear; Thomas Ligotti's fiction and his treatise *The Conspiracy Against the Human Race* (2010) made Zapffe's thesis the basis of a horror aesthetic in which the self is a puppet that has discovered its strings; and the first season of *True Detective* (2014), which drew on both, gave the mode a mass audience. Here the horror is not the universe but existence itself, and time appears as recurrence: a closed circle in which everything returns and nothing is redeemed.

Horror pleni is Moore's mode. Its cosmos is complete; nothing is ever lost; every act is permanent. The subject does not shrink but swells to infinite weight, because every moment of a life is eternal. Its figure of time is the block: a finished page. And unlike the other two, it has an obverse. The permanence that makes every atrocity eternal makes every grace eternal as well, and this *gloria pleni* is the consolation the corpus offers in exchange for its dread.

Mode	Representative works	Cosmos	Locus of dread	Fate of the subject	Figure of time	Moore's response
Horror vacui	Lovecraft, "The Call of Cthulhu" (1928); Hodgson, *The House on the Borderland* (1908)	Vast, ancient, indifferent; empty of human meaning	Knowledge: correlation discloses insignificance	Shrinks toward nothing	Deep time that dwarfs history	Correlation discloses infinite significance (*From Hell*, *Jerusalem*)
Horror vitae	Zapffe, "Den sidste Messias" (1933); Ligotti, *The Conspiracy Against the Human Race* (2010); *True Detective* (2014)	Indifferent; consciousness an aberration within it	Consciousness itself; the self as puppet	Exposed as mechanism	Recurrence as prison	The puppet as god: Glycon and the persona (Chapters 1, 5)
Horror pleni	Moore, *Miracleman* #15, *From Hell*, *Providence*, *Jerusalem*	Complete; nothing ever lost	Permanence: every atrocity always occurring	Swells to infinite weight	The block as finished page	*Gloria pleni*: every grace equally permanent

A single sign passes through all three modes and marks the hinges between them: Carcosa. In Ambrose Bierce's "An Inhabitant of Carcosa" (1886), a man wandering a ruined landscape discovers from his own gravestone that he died long ago — an eternalist epiphany, the view from nowhen, rendered as a ghost story. Robert W. Chambers made Carcosa the lost city of the fatal play in *The King in Yellow* (1895). *True Detective* made it the site of ritual atrocity and the stage for its detective's pessimist conviction that time is a closed circle in which everything recurs. Moore's Johnny Carcosa, the trafficker in Aklo who threads through *The Courtyard*, *Neonomicon*, and *Providence*, brings the sign into the plenary mode. The contrast with *True Detective* is instructive. Its detective, reading Nietzsche through pessimism, finds in recurrence a cage; Moore, reading Nietzsche through Minkowski, finds in permanence a weight that is also a gift.

The opposition between *horror vitae* and Moore's cosmology is sharpest at the figure of the puppet. Ligotti's early story "Dream of a Mannikin" and his later treatise treat the discovery that one is a puppet as the supreme horror, because it reveals agency as illusion. Moore holds the same premise and draws the opposite conclusion. His god is a puppet, and Kleist's grace — present only in the jointed doll and the god — appears at their coincidence. If we are puppets, the hand inside us is our own and our neighbours', and the voice that sounds through us is held in common.

10.2 The Veil and the Unveiling: Machen

Arthur Machen, a member of the Golden Dawn and the tutelary ghost of Moore's *Snakes and Ladders*, is the precursor whose vision Moore most directly inverts. In *The Great God Pan* (1894), Dr Raymond performs an operation on a young woman's brain to lift the veil of appearances so that she may see the god Pan; she sees, and is destroyed, and the daughter born of the encounter spreads ruin through London society. For Machen, whose sacramental Celtic Christianity understood the world as a veil over a terrible holiness, the unveiling of the real is ecstasy and annihilation at once. *Promethea*'s apocalypse is the same event with the opposite valence. The veil lifts for everyone, and what is revealed is not the destroying god but the imaginal ground of the world, which proves to be joyful. Moore keeps Machen's ecstasy and discards his sin.

Machen's legacy reaches Moore by two further routes already traced: the word *Aklo*, from "The White People" (1904), which becomes the language of perceptual infection in *The Courtyard* and *Neonomicon*; and the fate of "The Bowmen" (1914), the story that became a national legend despite its author. Machen is thus at once the source of Moore's most hopeful apocalypse and the documentary proof of his darkest thesis — that fictions escape into the world.

10.3 Revenants and Layered Time: James, Kneale, Garner, Holdstock

M. R. James's *Ghost Stories of an Antiquary* (1904) established the antiquarian ghost: a revenant summoned when a scholar disturbs an object from the past, as in "Oh, Whistle, and I'll Come to You, My Lad." China Miéville's essay "M. R. James and the Quantum Vampire" (2008) distinguished such *hauntological* horror, in which the past returns, from the *Weird* proper, in which something radically new — figured by the Lovecraftian tentacle — breaks into the world; Miéville coined *abcanny* for the Weird's affect, as distinct from the uncanny's return of the repressed. Moore's corpus fuses the two. *Providence* is Weird in Miéville's sense, *Jerusalem* hauntological; but in the block both the new and the returning are permanent, so the distinction between irruption and return dissolves. Nothing arrives from outside time and nothing comes back, because nothing ever left.

Nigel Kneale's television serial *Quatermass and the Pit* (1958–59) imagined an ancient Martian craft excavated beneath a London street called Hobbs End — "Hob" being an old name for the Devil — whose influence has shaped human mythology from below; the archaeology of the city is an archaeology of the psyche. Its resonance with Moore's *Voice of the Fire*, which opens with "Hob's Hog," may be coincidental, but the two works share a conviction that a place's deepest strata are imaginal. Kneale's *The Stone Tape* (1972), discussed in Chapter 8, made the place itself the recording medium.

Alan Garner is Moore's closest English contemporary in method. In *The Owl Service* (1967), three teenagers in a Welsh valley are compelled to re-enact the myth of Blodeuwedd from the *Mabinogion*, as previous generations in the same valley had done: the place is the score of a story that must be performed again. *Red Shift* (1973) braids three eras of one landscape; *Boneland* (2012) and *Treacle Walker* (2021) extend Garner's lifelong eternalism of place. Robert Holdstock's *Mythago Wood* (1984) supplies the nearest fictional realisation of Ideaspace in English fantasy: an ancient woodland that generates "mythagos," embodied figures of myth formed from the unconscious of those who enter it. Brian Catling's *The Vorrh* (2012), a novel Moore championed, extends the tradition of the mythic forest into colonial history. In all of these, as in *Voice of the Fire*, landscape is a medium in which imagination accumulates. Moore's distinctive move is to make that accumulation the substance of an afterlife.

British folk horror, as Adam Scovell (2017) has described it, binds landscape, isolation, and skewed belief into a summoning, as in *The Wicker Man* (1973),

where a sacrifice reasserts an old order. *From Hell*'s Gull is the folk-horror sacrificer translated into imperial London, and his sacrifice reasserts not a rural paganism but the solar order of empire.

10.4 Flesh, Dream, and Belief: Barker, Gaiman, Pratchett

Clive Barker's *Books of Blood* (1984–85) are framed by the story of a fraudulent medium upon whose skin the dead inscribe their stories, so that the living body becomes the text the dead write. The frame is the exact inverse of Mansoul. In Barker the dead are authors who write upon the living; in Moore they are readers who survey the living. Barker's *Weaveworld* (1987) preserves an entire world woven into a carpet, a cousin of *Promethea*'s final issue, in which a narrative becomes a single object; his *Imajica* (1991) ends in the reconciliation of divided realms, as *Swamp Thing* #50 ends in the integration of Darkness and Presence.

Neil Gaiman, who succeeded Moore on *Miracleman*, is the contemporary whose imaginal ontology lies closest to Moore's, and the difference between them is precise. In *The Sandman* (1989–96), the realm of dreams and stories is the Dreaming, and the Dreaming has a sovereign: it is a kingdom, governed by Dream of the Endless. Ideaspace in Moore has no sovereign; it is a commons. *Sandman*'s "Calliope" (#17) literalises the enclosure of the muse: a blocked novelist holds the Muse captive and violates her in order to harvest ideas, until Dream punishes him with an unbearable flood of them. "A Dream of a Thousand Cats" (#18) imagines collective dreaming remaking reality, the logic of *Promethea* and *Providence* in a fable. Gaiman's *American Gods* (2001) makes divine existence depend on worship, so that the old gods starve as attention migrates to the new gods of media and technology.

Terry Pratchett's Discworld formalised the same economy comically. In *Small Gods* (1992) the great god Om manifests as a tortoise because only one true believer remains; in *Hogfather* (1996) Death argues that human beings must practise believing small untrue things in order to be able to believe large necessary ones, such as justice and mercy; and L-space, introduced in *Guards! Guards!* (1989), connects all libraries because accumulated books distort space. These are among the most intelligent fictions of belief in the language. But they share with Gaiman an *attention economy* of the imagination, in which gods and stories are rivalrous goods that live and die by the share of attention they command. Moore's Ideaspace is non-rivalrous. In the block nothing imagined is ever lost, and a god forgot-

ten is not dead but unvisited. The difference is the difference between a market and a commons, and it underlies the political argument of Chapter 11.

10.5 The Rival Magus: Grant Morrison

Grant Morrison is Moore's only peer as a magician-writer of comics, and their public antagonism has obscured how precisely their cosmologies oppose one another. Morrison's *Animal Man* #26 (1990) brought its hero face to face with his writer; *Flex Mentallo* (1996) made the superhero a vehicle of psychedelic revelation; *The Invisibles* (1994–2000) was designed, by Morrison's account, as a hypersigil that reshaped its author's life; *Supergods* (2011) argued that superheroes are positive archetypes of human potential; and *The Multiversity* (2014–15) included a comic that addresses its reader as a haunted object. Morrison's magic descends from Spare and the chaos magic of Peter J. Carroll's *Liber Null* (1978); Moore's descends from the Hermetic Qabalah of the Golden Dawn.

Morrison has repeatedly proposed that comic characters are two-dimensional beings whom we, as higher-dimensional readers, observe and influence, and that we may in turn be observed by beings of a higher dimension still. The model resembles the death-as-readership of Chapter 8 and must be acknowledged as its nearest analogue. The differences are decisive. Morrison's readership is vertical: the reader is a higher being looking down from an ascending hierarchy of dimensions, and the cosmos is open, emergent, and progressive, tending toward a transcendent future that *The Invisibles* calls the Supercontext. Moore's readership is posthumous and horizontal: every human being becomes a reader, but only of their own completed life, and the cosmos is closed, finished, and judged by inquest rather than redeemed by ascent. Morrison regards the superhero as the redemptive myth of the age; Moore regards it as an infantilising and potentially authoritarian one. Morrison's universe is open and becoming; Moore's is complete and full.

10.6 Mythopoeia and Its Discontents: Tolkien, Lewis, Dunsany, Borges, Dick

J. R. R. Tolkien's "On Fairy-Stories" (delivered 1939, published 1947) defined the fantasist as a sub-creator, making a Secondary World in the image of the Primary Creator, and identified the genre's highest effect as *eucatastrophe*, the sudden joyous turn that offers consolation. Moore secularises sub-creation into creation without qualification: there is no Primary World above Ideaspace for the secondary to imitate. Michael Moorcock's essay "Epic Pooh" (1978) attacked the consolations of Tolkienian fantasy as politically conservative. Moore shares Moorcock's suspicion of escape but not his refusal of consolation; eternalism is a consolation that offers no escape. C. S. Lewis's *The Great Divorce*, discussed in Chapter 8, supplies the theological counterpoint — a Heaven that retroactively transfigures the past — which Moore's forensic eschatology declines.

Lord Dunsany's *The Gods of Pegāna* (1905) imagines the world as the dream of a sleeping god, kept asleep by a drummer, at whose waking all things will end. Reality as the fiction of a single dreamer is the sovereign model of the imaginal in its purest form, and Moore's collective, ownerless Ideaspace is its democratic opposite. Borges, already invoked for the Aleph and for Tlön, supplies a further foil in "Nueva refutación del tiempo" (1947), which constructs an idealist refutation of time only to concede at its close that time is the very substance of which the self is made. Borges's eternity is an ironic idealism; Moore's is a materialism without irony.

Philip K. Dick's visionary experiences of February and March 1974, worked into *VALIS* (1981), included the conviction that first-century Rome was superimposed upon 1970s California — that the Empire had never ended — and that the world was a prison of which gnosis might offer release. The parallel with Moore is striking: in 1994 a second-century Roman deity, Glycon, entered Moore's practice in Northampton. Both writers experienced the collapse of historical time as a Roman theophany. But Dick's gnosis was paranoid — the world as a prison, the revelation as escape — while Moore's was affirmative: the world as a theatre, the revelation as the discovery that the theatre is everyone's. Dick belongs to *horror vitae*; Moore converts the same experience into *gloria pleni*.

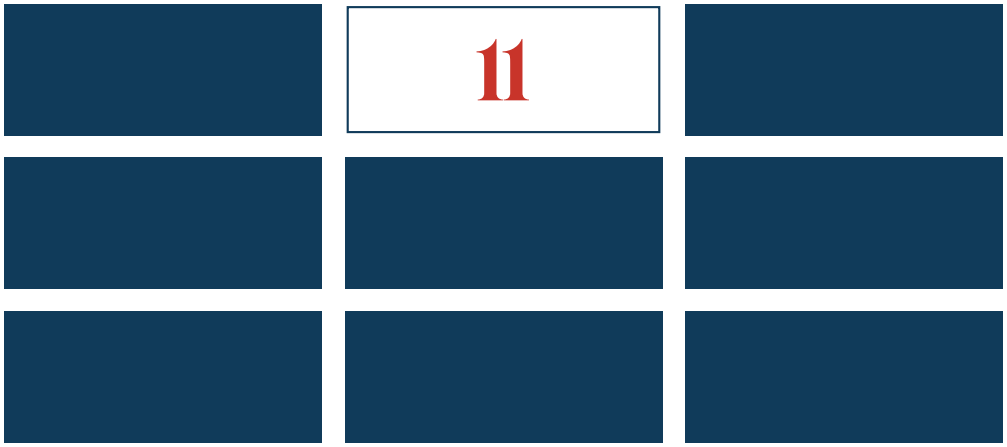
10.7 The Contemporary Weird: Miéville, Clarke, Jemisin, Fisher

Moore's later work coincides with a renaissance of the weird in British and American fiction, much of it in dialogue with the questions his work had posed. China Miéville's *Kraken* (2010) imagines London's religions and magics as a competitive ecosystem of belief, and *The City & The City* supplies, as Chapter 9 showed, the concept of unseeing on which *Providence* turns. Miéville's Marxist account of the Weird is the closest theoretical neighbour to Moore's politics of the imaginal.

Susanna Clarke's *Jonathan Strange & Mr Norrell* (2004) reconstructed a suppressed history of English magic, and her *Piranesi* (2020) offers the most beautiful contemporary image of Ideaspace: an infinite House of halls, statues, and tides, formed — in the theory of the transgressive scholar who discovered it — from the outflow of ancient modes of thought. Critics have aligned its metaphysics with Owen Barfield's history of participation. The novel's ethics divide exactly as Moore's do. The scholar who enters the House in search of power and secret knowledge is a counterfeit magus of the Gull type, an encloser; the innocent who lives in the House and reveres it is a commoner, whose relation to the imaginal is care rather than mastery.

N. K. Jemisin's *The City We Became* (2020) makes the boroughs of New York into living human avatars defending their city against an extradimensional enemy whose influence manifests as gentrification, bigotry, and homogenisation — a direct answer to Lovecraft's "The Horror at Red Hook." Its structure parallels *Jerusalem*'s sacralisation of a poor district against redevelopment and *Providence*'s account of a colonising imagination. Mark Fisher's *The Weird and the Eerie* (2016), finally, supplies the theoretical vocabulary within which Moore's work most naturally belongs: the weird as that which does not belong, and the eerie as the question of agency raised by a failure of absence or presence. Moore's corpus is both: weird in its plenitude of things that should not coexist, eerie in its diagnosis of a world driven by forces no one controls.

The comparison yields a conclusion. Moore shares with the weird tradition its interest in correlation, with the hauntological tradition its sense of persisting pasts, with the mythopoeic tradition its creation of secondary worlds, and with the contemporary weird its politics. What no other writer in these traditions shares is the combination of a completed time with an ownerless imagination. That combination is the subject of the final chapter.



The Gutter and the Plenum

Paginal Eternalism as a General Theory

The preceding chapters have read the corpus as a sequence of demonstrations. This chapter states the theory they demonstrate. It restates the four axioms of the Plenary Codex, derives from them Moore's definition of magic, formalises the eschatology of death as readership, articulates the gutter theology the corpus implies, defines the ethics of *horror pleni*, completes the theory of the imaginal commons, resolves the representational antinomy, confronts the principal objections, and proposes a method of reading other works by the same light.

11.1 The Four Axioms

Axiom	Statement	Correlate on the comics page	Principal genealogy	Principal demonstrations
I. Chrono-topic	Time is a completed solid; all moments are co-present	Every panel is simultaneously present on the page	Boethius, McTaggart, Minkowski, the Hintons	*Watchmen* IV and IX; Greyshirt's "How Things Work Out"; *Promethea* #32; *Jerusalem*
II. Imaginal	Ideas inhabit a real, collectively shared territory	Characters persist across artists, writers, and readers	Plato, Bruno, Jung, Popper, Corbin	*Promethea*'s Immateria; the *League*; Glycon; V as idea
III. Central	Every locus is the centre of the whole	Braiding: any panel may enter into relation with any other	Eliade, Borges, Mandelbrot, Blake	*From Hell*, Appendix II; *Voice of the Fire*; the Boroughs
IV. Noetic	Consciousness is the act of reading	Closure in the gutter; the reader's passage across the page	Augustine, McCloud, Bergson inverted	Dr Manhattan; Mansoul; the last panel of *Watchmen*

The axioms are not independent; they mutually entail one another. If time is a page (I) and consciousness is the reading of it (IV), then ideas — patterns that can be read by many readers at once — are places on the page that any reader may visit (II). And if every moment of the page is co-present, then every point stands in potential relation to every other, so that any locus, examined closely enough, discloses the whole (III). The Codex is a single intuition seen from four sides, and that intuition is the comics page: a finished surface of co-present images, whose characters are shared patterns, whose panels braid across the whole, and whose time exists only in the reader's passage.

11.2 The Paginal Entailment

Chapter 1 noted that Moore's definition of magic — the manipulation of symbols to change consciousness — places its emphasis on consciousness rather than on external events, and that the emphasis can look like a retreat from magic's traditional claims. The axioms show that it is not a retreat but a necessity. The argument runs as follows.

1. The universe is a completed four-dimensional structure in which no event can be other than it is (Axiom I).
2. Moore nonetheless holds that magic and art are efficacious: that they change something.
3. In a completed structure, what can change is not the structure but the relation between a consciousness and the structure — the reading (Axiom IV).
4. Therefore efficacious magic, if it exists at all, must consist in the alteration of consciousness.
5. Art alters consciousness by means of symbols. Therefore, in such a universe, art is magic in the strict sense, and magic is nothing other than art.

The conclusion is Moore's definition, derived rather than asserted. What appeared to be a psychologising evasion is the only coherent form of magical efficacy available in an eternalist cosmos, and the identity of art and magic, which Moore defends with philology and history, also follows from his physics. *Watchmen*'s thermodynamic miracle is the narrative proof. Manhattan changes nothing in the block except his reading of a single life, and the change in reading is sufficient to return him to the world.

An objection presents itself: is not the alteration of consciousness itself a fixed feature of the block? It is. Magic is not an escape from the page but a structure within it, as Rorschach's journal and Max Shea's pirate comic are pages within *Watchmen*; the block includes its own readings. Freedom therefore cannot be the power to make the page otherwise. It is the quality of the reading. This is, in substance, Spinoza's freedom. The *Ethica* (1677) defines as free "quae ex sola suae naturae necessitate existit, et a se sola ad agendum determinatur" — that which exists from the necessity of its own nature alone and is determined to act by itself alone — and locates the highest knowledge in the apprehension of things *sub specie aeternitatis*, under the aspect of eternity. Mansoul is the aspect of eternity made into a place. The magician is one who learns to see under that aspect while still in time, and the ethic that results is an *amor fati* without recurrence: love of

the fixed page because it is one's own.

11.3 Death as Readership: Four Positions

The Codex distributes beings among four positions relative to the page, and the corpus can be mapped onto them.

The first position is that of the *character*: the living, who move through their lives in sequence and experience the A-series present. The second is that of the *reader*: the dead of Mansoul, who survey their completed lives whole and can enter any moment. Between these lie the *visionaries*, who glimpse the reader's position involuntarily while still alive: the near-dead Michael Warren, the maddened Ernest Vernall, the serene Snowy Vernall, the confined John Clare and Lucia Joyce, and, in another key, Dr Manhattan. The third position is that of the *author*: the magician or artist who writes from within the page and thereby alters its reading — Sophie Bangs composing the poem that summons Promethea, Alma Warren painting the visions of *Jerusalem*, Valerie writing her letter, and Moore himself entering *Voice of the Fire* as its last voice. The magician, in the Codex's precise sense, is one who learns to read while still being written.

The fourth position is the *counterfeit*, and it has two forms. The counterfeit reader seizes the reader's vision by violence: Gull, who attains a view of the coming century through ritual murder, mutilating the text in order to read it. The counterfeit author rewrites the world, or other persons, without their consent: Veidt manufacturing an apocalypse from conscripted artists, Gargunza implanting dreams, Norsefire monopolising the voice of fate, the occult order of *Providence* colonising the imagination, and the corporations that rewrite characters against their makers' will. V occupies the boundary between author and counterfeit, and the work's refusal to decide his case is its moral seriousness. Black magic, in the Codex, is counterfeit readership or authorship: the appropriation of other persons as one's text.

The comparative argument of Chapter 10 locates this distribution. In Barker's *Books of Blood* the dead are authors; in Morrison's cosmology readers are higher beings; in Boethius only God reads the whole. Moore's distinctiveness lies in making readership posthumous, universal, and horizontal. Everyone becomes a reader, and the text each reads is their own life.

11.4 Gutter Theology

The Codex locates the sacred in a single place, the gutter, which the corpus superimposes in four registers.

The first register is formal. The gutter is the blank interval between panels in which, as McCloud showed, the reader performs closure — supplying the action, the motion, and the passage of time that no panel depicts. It is the only place on the page where nothing is drawn and where everything happens. In a determined page, it is also the only place where the reader acts.

The second register is theological. Isaac Luria's Kabbalah, as reconstructed by Gershom Scholem, began creation not with an act of emanation but with *tzimtzum*, a contraction in which the infinite withdrew from a region of itself in order to leave a void in which something other than God could exist. The gutter is the author's *tzimtzum*: the withdrawal of the image that makes room for the reader. In the completed universe of the Codex, where everything inscribed is fixed, the uninscribed interstice is the space of freedom, and grace is the gift of that space.

The third register is social. The gutter is where the poor live: the courts of Whitechapel and the terraces of the Boroughs, where Moore's corpus consistently finds its saints — Mary Kelly, Valerie, Evey, the Dead Dead Gang, Snowy Vernall. Wilde's line from *Lady Windermere's Fan*, one of this thesis's epigraphs, compresses the register: all are in the gutter, but some look at the stars.

The fourth register is the medium. The gutter press — the sensational newspapers that invented "Jack the Ripper" in *From Hell* — is the gutter as enclosure: the interstice filled in advance by commercial sensation, so that the reader's closure is supplied rather than performed. The gutter is therefore contested territory. It is the space in which the reader's imagination may act freely, and also the space that propaganda, advertising, and the franchise seek to occupy.

Gutter theology, so constituted, holds that the sacred is neither transcendent nor possessed but interstitial: it occurs in the act of connection, in the uninscribed space between fixed things, where readers make meaning that no author can make for them. The gutter is the commons of the page, unowned and shared by every reader. Wilde's sentence can then be completed in the Codex's terms. The stars are not only above the gutter; they are reflected in its water.

11.5 *Horror Pleni* and *Gloria Pleni*: *Einmal ist immer*

Milan Kundera's *The Unbearable Lightness of Being* (1984) opens with Nietzsche's eternal return and sets against it the German proverb *einmal ist keinmal* — what happens once might as well not have happened at all. A life lived only once, without recurrence, is unbearably light. The Codex inverts the proverb: *einmal ist immer*, once is forever. In the block, nothing that happens once is light, because nothing that happens ever ceases to be.

This is the formula of *horror pleni*: every atrocity the corpus depicts is permanently occurring, and there is no forgetting, no erasure, and no closure in the therapeutic sense, only completion. It is equally the formula of *gloria pleni*: every grace is permanent, and no act of love, courage, or witness is ever wasted. Three ethical consequences follow.

The first is that the whole life, not any single moment, is the unit of value. The Joker's thesis in *The Killing Joke* — that one bad day defines a person — is false in the block, where every day is present and the life is seen whole. The second is a forensic eschatology. Judgment is replaced by inquest: everything is seen and nothing is sentenced, so that accountability is total while punishment is absent. The third is that witness becomes the highest ethical act. Valerie's letter, Rorschach's journal, Alma Warren's paintings, and the annotations and appendices of *From Hell* are acts of witness. None of them changes the block; each changes its reading. Witness is the paginal entailment applied to ethics.

11.6 The Imaginal Commons: The Politics of the Plenum

Chapter 10 distinguished Moore's Ideaspace from the attention economies of Gaiman and Pratchett, in which gods starve when forgotten. Moore's Ideaspace is non-rivalrous: in the block, nothing imagined is lost, and one reader's use of an idea diminishes no other's. The political consequence is decisive. Scarcity in the imaginal is never natural; it is always imposed. Copyright extended without limit, and the franchise's regime of owned and policed characters, are forms of artificial scarcity imposed on an infinite resource. Enclosure is the cardinal crime of the corpus because it converts the one realm in which there need be no scarcity into a realm of property.

The two tensions left open in Chapter 3 can now be resolved. The first concerned the coexistence of Moore's defence of the commons with his assertion of authorial rights. The distinction that resolves it is between *use* and *extraction*. The commons permits use, transformation, and recombination, as the *League* uses the public domain; enclosure extracts exclusive profit against the integrity of the work and the will of its makers. Moore's objection to the corporate exploitation of his creations is a defence of integrity, not of exclusivity, and it is consistent with his own use of the commons. The second tension concerned the abuse of the commons itself. If characters are persons in Ideaspace, their integrity can be violated by any author, Moore included. This leads directly to the representational antinomy.

The politics of the plenum is not, finally, a politics of purity. The V mask, as Chapter 3 showed, is simultaneously the common emblem of protest and a licensed commodity. The struggle over the imaginal is conducted in the gutter, where closure can be performed freely or supplied by others, and it is never won once and for all.

11.7 The Representational Antinomy Resolved

Chapter 9 identified two propositions Moore cannot hold together: that fictions are real, and that fiction is a protected space whose contents harm no one. The Codex requires that the first be kept and the second abandoned. In a plenary cosmos, to depict is to build. A depiction adds a permanent structure to the common house of the imagination, and fiction is not unreal but differently located. The ethics of representation that follows can be stated as three criteria.

The first is *witness or consumption*. Does the depiction testify to harm, so that the reader's closure becomes an act of recognition, or does it offer harm as a pleasure to be consumed? The second is *the integrity of the depicted*. Does the work treat those it depicts as persons in Ideaspace, whose integrity is a claim on the author? This criterion is absolute in the case of children, whose sexualised depiction no appeal to fictionality can redeem. The third is *the freedom of the gutter*. Does the work leave the reader's closure free, or does it coerce it?

Applied to the corpus, the criteria discriminate. *Jerusalem* and the annotated, self-exposing witness of *From Hell* satisfy all three: they depict atrocity as testimony, honour the integrity of the dead, and leave the reader free. *V for Vendetta*'s coercion of Evey violates the third criterion within the story, but the work stages the violation self-consciously and leaves its judgment open, and so satisfies the criterion at the level of the whole. *Neonomicon* fails the first criterion for long stretches, in which violation is depicted at a length and with a specificity that exceed any testimonial function. *Lost Girls* fails the second decisively in its childhood material. The resolution, then, is not that fiction is reality — Moore is right that it is not — but that fiction is real. Every author answers in perpetuity for the rooms they add to the common house.

11.8 Objections and Limits

Several objections bear on the theory and on the corpus it describes.

The first is determinism. If every act is fixed, responsibility seems void. The Codex answers, with Spinoza, that freedom is a quality of action and understanding rather than a power to have done otherwise, and that an act's permanence makes it more fully one's own, not less.

The second is quietism. If nothing can be altered, resistance seems pointless. The answer is that resistance is itself a permanent feature of the block. V's acts, Valerie's letter, and Evey's choice are as eternal as the regime they oppose, and the value of an act lies in what it is, not in a change it might effect in an already complete universe.

The third concerns the magus. The corpus is persistently suspicious of its own heroes: Constantine manipulates, V coerces, Gull and Veidt are counterfeits, Jack Faust is a fraud. The magician is always one step from the counterfeit author. Moore's answer is to make magic a commons — the *Bumper Book of Magic* rather than the secret order — and to insist on the co-creative studio; but the tension is constitutive and cannot be wholly removed.

The fourth concerns appropriation. The Qabalah of *Promethea* is a Victorian Hermetic reworking of a Jewish mystical tradition whose historical integrity Scholem's scholarship established, and the correspondences Moore uses are detached from the religious community that produced their sources. Comparativism carries a related danger. The Aboriginal Australian concept that W. E. H. Stanner (1953) rendered as the "everywhen" offers an apparent analogue to eternalism, but it belongs to living religious systems and cannot responsibly be assimilated to a European metaphysics, however sympathetic.

The fifth concerns gender. *From Hell* marks the matriarchal myth as a patriarchal fiction, but *Promethea*'s cosmology of feminine principles, and the lunar devotion of the Moores' magical practice, draw on the same Bachofen–Graves tradition that Cynthia Eller has criticised as essentialist. The corpus contains some of the most fully realised women in comics — Evey, Laurie, Abby, Mina, Sophie, Halo Jones, Alma — and also a recurrent use of sexual violence against women as a narrative engine, which Section 11.7's criteria judge.

The sixth is unfalsifiability. Popper's World 3 is a theory of objective knowledge — problems, arguments, theories — and would not admit gods. Ideaspace exceeds what any empirical method could confirm. Moore's implicit answer is that Ideaspace is a working hypothesis judged by its fruits, as an artistic method is

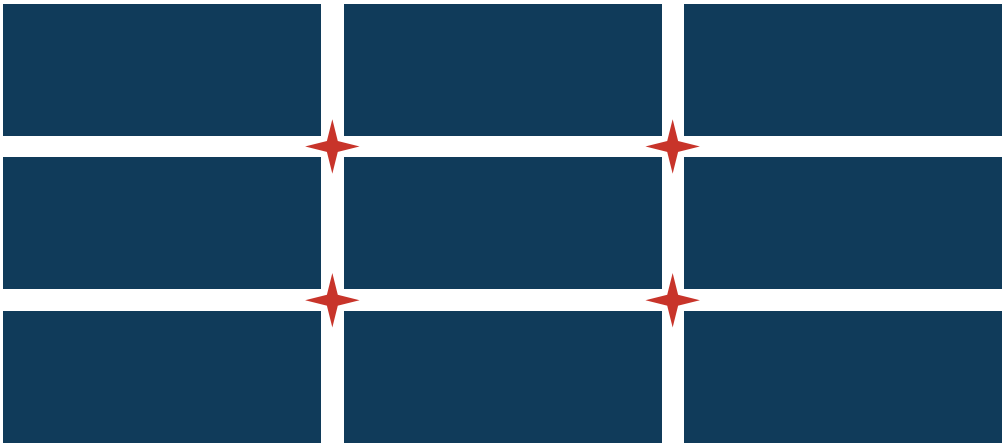
judged; the answer is honest but does not convert the hypothesis into knowledge, and this thesis treats it accordingly, as an ontology implicit in a practice rather than a doctrine to be believed. Finally, there is the paradox of success. Moore's critique of enclosure depends in part on the cultural reach of the very works that were enclosed. *Watchmen* is at once the corpus's most rigorous achievement and one of the most valuable properties of the company Moore repudiated. The pharmakon cannot be refused; it can only be read.

11.9 Toward a Plenary Criticism

The Codex yields a method applicable beyond Moore. It consists of five questions that may be asked of any imaginative work.

1. What is its chronotope: open, branching, recurrent, or completed?
2. What is its imaginal ontology: a sovereign realm, an attention market, or a commons?
3. Where is its locus of dread: the void, life itself, or plenitude?
4. What does it leave to the reader in its gutters, and is that space free or occupied?
5. Who owns the imaginal, both within the work and in the conditions of its production?

Applied briefly, the questions sort works with economy. Gaiman's *The Sandman* is a sovereign realm whose sovereign must die and be replaced — a monarchy reformed rather than abolished — and its melancholy belongs closer to *horror vitae* than to plenitude. Morrison's *The Invisibles* is open and emergent, its commons achieved through transformation rather than preservation. Clarke's *Piranesi* is a commons revered by its innocent and violated by its magus. Jemisin's *The City We Became* defends a city as commons against a colonising imagination. In each case the questions disclose a position on the same axes Moore's corpus occupies at their extreme. Plenary criticism thus names a family of works — fictions that treat the imagination as a commons and time as a completed whole — and Moore's corpus is its most complete member.



Conclusion

The Drowned Book

The last volume of *The League of Extraordinary Gentlemen*, which closed Moore's career in comics in 2019, ends where Shakespeare's late play ends: with a magician renouncing his art. Prospero promises to break his staff and bury it, "And deeper than did ever plummet sound / I'll drown my book." Moore's farewell to the medium he had transformed borrowed the gesture, and the press reported it as a retirement.

The argument of this thesis is that, in the cosmology Moore spent five decades constructing, no book can be drowned. A book sunk beyond the reach of any plummet is still a book. It lies at a depth no instrument measures, but it lies there, entire, as every panel remains on the page after the reader's eye has passed on. Prospero's renunciation is one more panel; Moore's farewell to comics is one more panel in a work that continues in prose, where *The Great When* has opened an imaginal London that preserves what the bombed city lost. In a plenary universe, endings are not erasures but completions. Nothing is finished in the sense of being over; things are only finished in the sense of being whole.

The thesis has argued that this conviction is not one theme among many in Moore's work but the principle that generates it. Beneath the apparent ruptures of the career — from superhero revisionism to Hermetic magic, from the urban

Gothic to the provincial epic — lies a single cosmology, the Plenary Codex, whose four axioms are the formal properties of the comics page raised into a metaphysics: time is a completed page; ideas are places; every place is the centre; consciousness is reading. From these axioms the principal commitments of the corpus follow. Magic, in a universe where events cannot be altered, can only be the alteration of consciousness, and is therefore identical with art — the paginal entailment. Death is the passage from character to reader of one's own completed life, and judgment gives way to inquest. The sacred is located in the gutter: the formal interstice where the reader's closure occurs, the social gutter where the dispossessed live, the contraction in which the author withdraws to make room for freedom, and the contested space that the gutter press and the franchise seek to occupy. The characteristic affect of the corpus is *horror pleni*, the dread of a universe in which nothing is lost, inseparable from its obverse, *gloria pleni*. And its politics is the defence of an imaginal commons against enclosure — the cardinal crime of the corpus, committed by fascist states, patriarchal myths, utilitarian technocrats, colonising mythologies, and the corporations that own Moore's creations.

The thesis makes six contributions. It replaces the partitioned author of Moore criticism with a unified reading that accounts for the career's continuities and its ruptures alike. It identifies the comics page as a metaphysical model, connecting the formal analysis of McCloud and Groensteen to the philosophy of time from Boethius to Minkowski. It derives Moore's definition of magic from his eternalism, showing that what has looked like mystical evasion is logical necessity. It grounds Moore's quarrel with the comics industry in the long history of enclosure, from the Midland Revolt to the intellectual-property regime, and theorises the imagination as a non-rivalrous commons. It proposes a taxonomy of cosmic dread — *horror vacui*, *horror vitae*, *horror pleni* — within which Moore's distinctiveness among the weird, haunted, and mythopoeic traditions becomes precise. And it judges Moore by his own premises, identifying the representational antinomy at the centre of his practice and resolving it in favour of his metaphysics against his defences: fiction is not reality, but fiction is real, and the author answers for what is built.

Three directions for further research follow. The first is the *Long London* sequence, whose later volumes will test whether the imaginal city extends or revises the cosmology of *Jerusalem*. The second is the afterlife of Moore's signs in political culture — above all the Guy Fawkes mask — which offers an unusually documented case of a fiction escaping into the commons while remaining enclosed as

a commodity. The third is the application of plenary criticism to the broader field of comics, where the page's co-presence makes every work an implicit model of time, and where the ownership of characters makes every franchise an implicit politics of the imagination.

Blake's *Jerusalem*, from which this thesis took its first epigraph, insists that one must create a system or be enslaved by another's. Moore created a system, and its final teaching is an ethic of building. If nothing is lost, then everything made is permanent, and the obligation that follows is not to escape the block but to build well within it — to add to the common house of the imagination rooms in which others can live. Blake's preface to *Milton* called this labour "Mental Fight" and named its object Jerusalem. Moore relocated the building site to the gutter at the bottom of the hill, where Wilde's figures lie looking at the stars.

The drowned book lies where it fell, entire, in the dark water of the gutter. Whoever looks down into that water will find the book there — and, reflected on its surface, the stars.



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